

Section 30: On the Usage and Definition of Concepts

As we conclude this massive, hundred-thousand-word chapter, it is inevitable that I have introduced original concepts, some of which may push the boundaries of conventional terminology. Therefore, I establish here the precise definitional criteria I apply to historical nomenclature, offering them to the reader for reference and rigorous critique.

Class vs. Stratum (阶级与阶层): Although the usage of "class" and "stratum" has long been conflated, I argue that a fundamental distinction must be maintained. I absolutely reject the notion of categorizing the state apparatus or the bureaucracy as a "class." In my view, the term "class" must denote that its subject is intrinsically linked to a specific *mode of production* (生产方式). That is to say, when a group of people is defined as a class, the defining characteristic of this set is that its "elements" universally adopt a specific mode of production to directly generate productive forces. It is precisely because classes participate in labor and production through various means that they can shape human civilization from technological, cultural, artistic, and relational perspectives. This actually echoes the consistent Marxist view that historical development is driven by the movement of various classes. Regarding the theoretical completeness of Marx and Engels' original framework, we need not outright deny it; rather, we should distill its authentic core from historical distortions (去伪存真), making it logically self-consistent and universally applicable.

Unlike a class, the state apparatus or bureaucracy is fundamentally *detached from material production* (脱产的). While one can certainly argue that it occupies a specific position within the relations of production, and even fulfills crucial social functions, it is emphatically *not* anchored to any specific mode of production. By drawing this line, we place the bureaucracy in a highly specific, separate position within the narrative of class analysis—a distinction that proves highly advantageous.

Similarly, one can observe that the elements within the set of "intellectuals" do not necessarily share a common mode of production. Therefore, they should be classified as an *intellectual stratum*, not an intellectual class. A salient difference between a class and a stratum is that classes emerge and are eliminated along with the evolution of eras—a process fundamentally determined by the birth and obsolescence of modes of production. Conversely, a stratum that performs a specific social function can persist for an exceedingly long time, because social functions do not necessarily vanish with the shifts in social formations brought about by class movements. There was a bureaucratic stratum and an intellectual stratum in the Sumerian period, just as there are in today's world, despite a span of five thousand years.

We must also note that a subset of a stratum can highly likely be classified as a class. While the stratum as a whole may lack a uniform mode of production, a specific segment of it might not. Take, for instance, the priests in early states. Setting aside their religious and administrative nature, priests—as a segment of intellectuals serving as a labor component—invested their knowledge into agricultural production and engineering construction. They did, indeed, generate productive forces through a specific mode of production. Therefore, designating priests as a "priestly class" is largely permissible. This explains why, when discussing the ruling classes of early states, priests are usually counted among their ranks.

Finally, I posit that merchants—specifically itinerant traders who are not responsible for producing goods but solely handle the circulation phase—should be viewed as a stratum rather than a class. As readers will see in the main text, this categorization is highly instrumental in explaining "*trade-based pseudo-classical states*" (贸易型伪古典国家) and "*late-classical states*." Furthermore, we must point out that while merchants are indispensable for their vital social function, they cannot serve as the primary creators of culture within a large-scale system. Only in societies like the Sogdian city-states—where the demographic scale is relatively small, yet situated on primary trade routes with an immense volume of trade—can commercial culture assume a dominant role.

Feudal economic system (封建经济制度): Refers to an economic system characterized by individual small-scale production as the primary production model, tenancy as the primary operational method, or—to phrase it more left-leaning—as the primary mode of exploitation (the above being the "feudal mode of production"), with pronounced features of a natural economy. The basic unit of economic production is generally the manor. The form of land rent undergoes changes with the development of the feudal economy; generally speaking, it transitions from *corvée* rent to rent in kind and then to money rent. After feudal landlords at various levels achieve political dominance and become feudal lords, the feudal society should exhibit the characteristic of large-scale landownership, meaning that land, through various forms of annexation, reaches a high level of concentration. Serfdom exists to varying degrees; due to different specific environments, the strength of the peasants' dependence on the lords varies, but in any case, it is weaker than early slavery. The urban economy belonged as an appendage to the manor in the Early Middle Ages (中世纪早期), but had already achieved a certain degree of independence in the High Middle Ages (中世纪盛期), with obvious development in long-distance commercial activities, monetary economy, and autonomy.

Mainstream Mode of Exploitation (主流剥削方式): Within Soviet-style historiography, class societies and the mainstream mode of exploitation dominant within that society possess a phenomenally rigid corresponding relationship. According to the orthodox perspective I was taught during my student years, the mainstream mode of exploitation in a *slavery society* (奴隶制社会) is the forcible seizure of surplus labor (剩余劳动) via forced labor; the mainstream mode of exploitation in a *feudal society* (封建社会) is the plunder of surplus product (剩余产品) via land rent; and the mainstream mode of exploitation in a capitalist society is the acquisition of surplus value (剩余价值) via the wage-labor relationship. However, the definitional chaos within the domain of social sciences in our nation vastly exceeds the imagination of outsiders. Frequently, individuals in China identically categorize the surplus labor acquired through exploitation under slavery, as well as the surplus product acquired under the feudal system, directly as a variant of surplus value, merely imbued with a potent extra-economic (超经济) attribute.

We must concede that the observations of Soviet-style historiography are not entirely devoid of merit; obviously, the mainstream mode of exploitation and the taxonomy of a class society unequivocally possess a robust corresponding relationship. Yet the issue resides in the fact that

historical realities demonstrate it is exceedingly arduous for people to assume that a society taxonomized as a *feudal society* inevitably features the collection of land rent as its absolute mainstream mode of exploitation.

During the Early and High Middle Ages, the manorial system (庄园制) under a *natural economy* (自然经济) universally possessed an institutionalized regime of forced labor. For instance, the well-known "3+3+1 model" within medieval European feudal agricultural production: serfs bound to the lord's land were compelled to toil uncompensated for the lord for three days; they were required to bring their own primary means of production to the lord's demesne (自营地) to execute uncompensated forced labor. The serfs could then toil for three days upon their holding (份地), and the grain produced upon this holding sustained the serf's family. Sunday was the Sabbath, during which agricultural labor was strictly prohibited. Beyond this standardized model of exploitation, the *corvée* (劳役) exacted upon serfs during busy agricultural seasons could be significantly aggravated. Furthermore, fundamentally not all peasants operated on this "three days on, three days off" schedule. Semi-serfs possessing excessively scant land were fundamentally incapable of sustaining the standardized quota of *corvée*, and could only secure grain by working as hired hands for wealthy peasants or lords. Conversely, freeholders (自由农) were generally exempt from enduring forced *corvée*, primarily paying rent in kind or in monetary currency.

Although individuals conventionally regard the "corvée rent" (劳役地租) of the medieval European manorial system as a specific typology of land rent paid utilizing labor power, this remains fundamentally incapable of camouflaging its intrinsic essence as forced labor. Only upon reaching the Late Middle Ages did *corvée* rent transition on a massive scale into rent in kind or monetary rent; this was identically the historical epoch wherein the manorial economy thoroughly disintegrated. Certain momentous historical events, such as the Black Death, accelerated this process.

Observing the history of Japan will yield the identical conclusion. Subsequent to the disintegration of the manorial economy in the late Middle Ages (中世晚期) of Japan, rent/taxes unequivocally became the mode of exploitation occupying an overwhelming majority across the entirety of society. The *Taikō Kenchi* (太阁检地 / Toyotomi Hideyoshi's land surveys) established quintessential rent-based exploitation via the *Kokudaka* system (石高制) and the annual tribute (*nengu* / 年供). It was merely that Japan's *commodity economy* (商品经济) remained insufficient to rival Western Europe, thus the proportion of tax in kind within its land taxation remained higher. Therefore, if we strictly adhere to Soviet-style historiography—perceiving the epoch where the mode of exploitation corresponding to a class society dominates the entirety of society as its quintessential phase—then this specific phase genuinely would not be excessively protracted. Taking the *feudal period* (封建时期) as an example, after less than two centuries and merely a few generations, alongside the development of urban commerce and industry, wage labor began to play an increasingly pivotal role within the socio-economy; the *feudal society* began to

manifest faltering instability, and history transitioned into what people conventionally term the "early modern era" (早期近代).

Consequently, Soviet-style historiography inevitably generates certain sensory contradictions. Regardless of whether viewed by the historiographical community or ordinary citizens, the epoch where the *feudal political system* (封建体制) was *de facto* at its most mature and quintessential was precisely the High Middle Ages spanning from 1000 AD to 1300 AD. During this epoch, the contractual network predicated upon (cross-generational) land subinfeudation and lord-vassal relationships blanketed the terrain of Western Europe; superior lords relied upon the military service of subordinate lords and acknowledged their right to possess land. The *natural economy* identically retained its dominant positioning, and the manorial system—spawned organically beneath this natural economy—functioned flawlessly. The *feudal lord* (领主) resided within the manor, and serfs toiled on the lord's demesne via forced labor. The societal structure was phenomenally, flawlessly theorized into three estates (三个等级): namely, those who pray, those who fight, and those who work. Feudal religious organizations—namely, the Roman Catholic Church—saw their authority crest at its absolute zenith, shouldering a colossal volume of societal functions. These all constitute the quintessential humanistic landscapes of the *feudal system* (or the Middle Ages) as conventionally perceived by people.

Conversely, upon reaching the Late Middle Ages, standing armies and mercenary forces became ubiquitous; 諸侯 (vassals) no longer necessarily served in person, and the feudal military system underwent monumental mutations. The manorial system disintegrated, the *commodity economy* recovered, the burgher stratum expanded, and the Reformation was already brewing. Even if the Late Middle Ages was still technically a *feudal society*, its humanistic landscape had already mutated profoundly. Yet paradoxically, strictly according to the Soviet-style historiographical perspective of correlating exploitation modes with class societies, it was exactly during the Late Middle Ages that the supposedly quintessential *feudal society* finally emerged.

These deficiencies in the interpretive framework of Soviet-style historiography precisely reflect the significance of this manuscript's approach in defining class societies via the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素).

In reality, people can readily discern that even if superficially the phenomenon of slaves within *early states* (早期国家) or *classical empires* (古典帝国) sweating profusely on plantations appears similar to the serfs of the Early and High Middle Ages enduring *corvée* on the lord's demesne—both ostensibly constituting "forced labor"—there exists, after all, a conspicuous distinction: the forced labor within a *feudal society* (封建社会) is predicated upon land attachment relations. Slaves do not possess any means of production whatsoever, nor do they even possess any private property; they struggle to exert control even over their own physical bodies. They themselves are perceived as private property that the master can dispose of arbitrarily (particularly regarding buying and selling). A slave's necessary labor and surplus labor are thoroughly conflated in time and space; the master appropriates virtually the entirety of the slave's output, exclusively allocating an infinitesimally small fraction of livelihood materials to sustain the slave's physical survival.

By contrast, serfs enjoy a certain degree of legal personhood and partially possess means of production—specifically possessing the *usufruct* (用益权) of their holding (份地). Serfs cannot be bought and sold arbitrarily exactly like livestock, nor can they be slaughtered by the *feudal lord* (领主) at will; generally, they can exclusively change masters alongside the transfer of the land. The forced labor exacted upon serfs is identically lucidly severed in time and space. For instance, the fruits of three days of labor on their own holding per week belong to themselves, whilst the fruits of three days of uncompensated labor on the lord's land belong to the lord. The obligations between the serf and the lord are identically not entirely unidirectional; the latter must identically provide judicial services and military protection for the former.

Consequently, we can observe that even if land rent had not yet become the mainstream mode of exploitation during the Early and High Middle Ages, land had already occupied the absolute core positioning within social production, morphing into the *primary factor of production*. The "feudal attributes" (封建属性) of the society are utterly indisputable; this identically explains exactly why the terminology "corvée rent" (劳役地租) exists. By utilizing the *primary factor of production* to define class societies, historical periodization becomes astronomically more straightforward and lucid, preventing individuals from plunging into conceptual conflation.

Exactly as articulated in Section 5 of Chapter 13 of this manuscript, even regarding the exact same vocabulary, its intrinsic connotations are fundamentally not identical beneath differing societal morphologies. Here, we shall tentatively utilize an illustration predicated upon Marxist interpretations. In a *feudal society*, land rent—whether it be the corvée rent of the early and middle phases or the rent in kind and monetary rent of the late phase—constitutes virtually the absolute entirety of the society's mode of exploitation. The lord's exploitation of the serf is fundamentally not predicated upon market contracts, but entirely relies upon his political privileges and extra-economic coercive power (超经济的强制力). If the serf fails to pay rent, the lord can deploy his judicial apparatus and military forces to execute suppression.

Within a capitalist society, land remains a pivotal means of production, and land rent identically continues to exist. However, the standardized agricultural structure of capitalism is "tripartite": the land owner leases the land to the agricultural capitalist, and the agricultural capitalist subsequently hires agricultural workers to toil upon the land. Thus, land rent exclusively becomes a mere fraction of the surplus value; the authentic act of exploitation occurs via the process of the agricultural capitalist paying wages to the hired workers. The agricultural capitalist extracts a specific fraction from the total profit, delivering it to the land owner as rent for utilizing the land. Within a capitalist society, land rent possesses absolutely zero extra-economic coercive characteristics. Contemporary landlords fundamentally cannot deploy extrajudicial lynchings to coerce the land lessee into paying rent; their actions must inherently be predicated upon economic contracts, legal property rights, and market norms. Therefore, in the early modern society subsequent to the conclusion of the Middle Ages, even if the collection of land rent remained the mainstream mode of exploitation for a protracted duration, this fundamentally did not impede the *feudal society* from transitioning toward a capitalist society, because the intrinsic nature possessed by land rent was undeniably undergoing mutation.

Soviet-style historiography harbors yet another flaw: it frequently and simplistically categorizes the forced labor practices existing within the manorial economy as mere "vestiges of slavery" (奴隶制残余), thereby imbuing it with a potentially derogatory coloration. However, the factual reality is obviously not that simplistic. Leaving aside the fact that the transition between socio-developmental stages inherently necessitates a protracted duration, the existence of the manorial economy identically possesses its positive significance.

This is beyond the fundamental elevation in the status and treatment of the serfs themselves relative to slaves, which we have already discussed. Under the state of a *natural economy* where the *commodity economy* has withered, the manor is not merely an administrative unit, but identically the absolute core of agricultural production. If the lord exclusively collected monetary currency from the peasants, that currency would be phenomenally difficult to spend. If he exclusively collected physical commodities, the lord's entire family would plunge into crisis upon encountering a famine year when the peasants failed to deliver. Under such a state, in order to maintain his physical survival and military logistics, the lord necessitated the direct, manual control over a specific fraction of core land—namely, the so-called *demesne*.

The organization of production by *resident feudal lords* (在地领主) via forced *corvée* possessed undeniable positive significance. They provided infrastructure and means of production, executed resource integration, managed production, and simultaneously established order and bore responsibility for security. The direct participation and intervention in the production process by *resident feudal lords* and manorial bailiffs (庄园管家)—from which they derived profit—identically stimulated their enthusiasm for agricultural amelioration. The spatial proximity in residence between the rulers and the ruled, coupled with their shared focus upon productive labor, was strictly necessary for the formation of the spirit of feudal contracts. Although the status between the lord and the serf was astronomically unequal, it nevertheless constituted a contractual relationship mutually beneficial to both parties at the time; the lord identically needed to shoulder the obligations of managing, producing within, and protecting the manor. Although the internal judicial practices of the manor safeguarded the feudal hierarchy, they identically crystallized customary law, thereby catalyzing the consciousness of rules within grassroots society.

In summary, although the manorial economy possessed the exploitative essence of forced labor, it nevertheless accommodated the abysmally low level of productive forces and the chaotic societal reality of that era. It successfully organized the dispersed population, propelled the iteration of agricultural technology, and established a feudal order centered absolutely around contracts and land.

Once the Late Middle Ages arrived, the manorial economy disintegrated, and rent in kind alongside monetary rent became the mainstream mode of exploitation. Paradoxically, the *feudal lords* (封建领主) consequently withdrew from the management of agricultural production, no longer intervened directly, and thus cared significantly less than before. The manor as a unified production unit vanished; what remained now was merely a pure "rent-collection jurisdiction." The lords' withdrawal from production and their transmutation into absentee landlords (不在地主) and court

aristocrats portended that the *feudal system* (封建制度) had peaked and was inexorably descending into decline. When the lord withdrew from organizing production and ceased playing the roles of military and judicial protector as well as the provider of the means of production, he identically ceased to be a "legitimate protector and manager" in the eyes of the peasants, and increasingly approximated the role of a parasite.

Soviet-style historiography conventionally harbors a specific predilection: namely, the assumption that "quintessential class societies are protracted and stable, whereas the transitional periods between them are astronomically briefer." Yet the historical truth we observe is fundamentally not like this. The duration for which quintessential class society morphologies (as defined by Soviet-style historiography) exist is decidedly not protracted, virtually never exceeding two centuries, or the timespan of ten generations. Furthermore, even if we incorporate the transitional states between class societies—redefined by this manuscript as the *classical society* (古典社会) and the *early modern society* (近世社会)—as historical stages standing in parallel with the three main class societies, these "standardized societal morphologies" across the *historical sequence* (历史序列) are fundamentally not protracted; rather, the evolutionary processes between them occupy the overwhelming majority of historical epochs. This identically reinforces the perspective of this manuscript once again: societal revolution is undeniably a long-term enterprise.

Specific to China, Soviet-style historical propaganda has been amplified due to China's idiosyncratic historical trajectory. Certain historical narratives are phenomenally radical; for instance, some point out that commencing from the "Initial Tax on Land Acreage" (初税亩) in the State of Lu (鲁国) at the genesis of the sixth century BC, and traversing a series of reform movements across various vassal states during the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods, China—even during the early phase of its classical empire's unification—was already a nation predominantly featuring a *feudal economic system* (封建经济制度) where land rent constituted the mainstream mode of exploitation, and this state persisted relentlessly until the ultimate dynasty, the Qing. However, in reality, sagacious individuals can discern that this narrative is profoundly problematic. The Chinese empire collected the poll tax (人头税) for a protracted duration, which fundamentally constitutes a tax levied upon labor power. Taking the Han Dynasty—a *classical empire*—as an example, the official, fixed land tax was perpetually maintained at an exceedingly low rate, yet the poll tax (known as the *Kou Fu* / 口赋) imposed an astronomically heavy burden upon the populace. If one further considers the crushing corvée (徭役) that the Han government compelled the commoners to endure, it seems there is a severe deficit of rationale to presume that land rent in classical-era China had already surpassed forced labor to become the mainstream mode of exploitation.

Within our nation's history, the monumental epoch marking the shift of the exploitation's center of gravity from labor power to land ought to be the implementation of the "Two-Tax System" (两税法) during the middle and late Tang Dynasty. It is highly probable that it was not until the terminus of the first millennium AD that land rent truly became the mainstream mode of exploitation within

Chinese society. This temporal node is phenomenally fascinating; it is, of course, astronomically later than the chronological node posited by official historiography, yet identically vastly earlier than when the *feudal societies* of Europe and Japan transitioned from corvée rent to rent in kind or monetary rent.

To a certain extent, this reflects the maturation of the *restoration-bureaucratic system* (复辟官僚制度) itself: it no longer attempted to combat *feudalization* (封建化) via directly controlling and distributing land, exactly as the Sui and early Tang dynasties had done; conversely, it transitioned toward sustaining itself predicated upon acknowledging the formation of the *feudal economic system*. Permitting the landlord class to exploit via rent/taxes was inherently advantageous to the bureaucratic system itself. Once China's landlord class ceased to act exactly like the *resident feudal lords* of the Early and High Middle Ages (as well as those of early medieval China)—who established manors, provided agricultural means of production, organized micro-level production, and protected peasants using private armed forces—and instead transitioned to relying utterly upon the court's laws and the local magistracy's (衙门) coercive power to extract rent, they mutated into parasites fundamentally devoid of any organizational contribution regarding the development of productive forces. This, conversely, further annihilated the possibility of them transmuting into genuine *feudal lords*.

Therefore, dramatically enough, an earlier transition into an economic model of exploiting land rent not merely inflicted a political catastrophe upon China, but it ultimately identically stagnated development within the economic sphere. For instance, a universally acknowledged fact is that the institutionalized exploitation of labor power concluded phenomenally late in our nation; the poll tax was not thoroughly abolished until the mid-Qing Dynasty. By that epoch, the Western world and Japan had already entered the *early modern society* long ago. China's history genuinely proves—from a diametrically negative inverse—the positive historical significance of the manorial economy during the Early and High Middle Ages.

A principle that individuals ought to bear constantly in mind whilst reading Chinese history is this: although a *natural economy* (自然经济) undeniably signifies the atrophy of a *commodity economy* (商品经济), it identically signifies the demise of the forced circulation orchestrated by the bureaucratic system for the purpose of extracting social wealth. Furthermore, what destructs a *natural economy* is not necessarily the development of a *commodity economy*; it is identically highly probable to be the reconstructed bureaucratic system resuming its extraction of social wealth.

The history of Chūsei Japan provides an intra-systemic comparison within the *feudal society* (封建社会). We have previously pointed out that during the epoch when the Shōen-Kōryō system (庄园公领制 / manor and public land system) remained operative in Japan's Middle Ages, Japanese manors identically possessed a system of forced labor imbued with indigenous characteristics. However, it is noteworthy that throughout the entire historical epoch marking the emergence of the Japanese manorial system, the proportion of rent/taxes within the mode of exploitation was highly likely larger than that of the Early and High Middle Ages in Europe.

On one hand, this is because Japan's *feudalization* (封建化) was incubated upon the ruins of a highly mature Ritsuryō state (律令国家 / statutory state), wherein the inertia of the "Zu-Yō-Chō" (租庸调 / tax in kind, labor, and local products) system persistently existed. A more pragmatic reason, conversely, is that Japan's *feudal system* (封建制度) was not established via conquest by *barbarians* (蛮族) *entering the pass* (入关), but rather through samurai groups incrementally usurping political power from within the state apparatus.

The Shōen-Kōryō system chronically maintained a separation between ownership and management rights; the supreme owners of the manor were the court aristocrats and prominent temples/shrines situated far away in Kyoto. Because they were not locally situated within the manor, they naturally necessitated reliance upon the Azukari-dokoro (预所 / deputies), Geshi (下司 / local managers), and Myōshu (名主 / wealthy tenant farmers) to progressively transport the annual tribute (*nengu*) of the manor to Kyoto. Since it was fundamentally impossible for them to travel to the countryside to personally supervise the peasants' labor, it was identically impossible for them to reverse the relatively pure form of corvée rent (劳役地租) exacted by the *resident feudal lords* (在地领主) during the Early and High Middle Ages of Europe. Consequently, if analyzed from the perspective of Soviet-style historiography, since land rent occupied a higher proportion within the mode of exploitation in Japan's early Middle Ages compared to contemporary Europe, wouldn't Japan's degree of feudalization be even higher than Europe's? We know this is obviously absurd.

The transmutation of manorial Geshi and Myōshu into samurai was decidedly not accomplished overnight. I postulate that it is more appropriate to define Japan's High Middle Ages (中世盛期) as the Sengoku period (战国时期), an epoch when the manorial system had already disintegrated. The Sengoku Daimyo (战国大名) virtually, entirely eliminated the intervention of the public power of the Ritsuryō state upon production, actualizing the monopoly and monolithic domination (一元化支配) over land. Via the *Bunkokuhō* (分国法 / domain laws), they established pure feudal contracts and military lord-vassal relationships within their own territories; they orchestrated water management, reclaimed gold mines, and organized production within their domains according to their own requirements. These constitute the hallmarks of a *feudal system* reaching its absolute zenith structurally.

Subsequently, Japan's Late Middle Ages (中世晚期) ought to be defined as the epoch under the Shokuhō regime (织丰政权); the *feudal lords* (封建领主) began to disengage from agricultural production, a colossal volume of lower-tier samurai transmuted into professional soldiers receiving fixed stipends, and the mode of exploitation comprehensively transitioned into rent/taxes. This identically corroborates what we articulated when discussing Japan in Chapter Four: Europe's High Middle Ages concurrently represented the flourishing epoch of the manorial system, whereas during Japan's High Middle Ages, the manorial system had already collapsed.

Japan's High and Late Middle Ages manifested conspicuous tardiness alongside rapid transitional velocity. The fundamental rationale lies in the fact that although Japan's *feudalization* was dragged down by the statutory bureaucratic system for several centuries, over this protracted timespan, Japan's level of agricultural production and *commodity economy* were persistently developing. Therefore, when the Sengoku Daimyo ultimately, thoroughly shattered the shackles of the bureaucratic system, Japan's social productive forces had already breached the confines of the feudal *natural economy*. The deluge of the *commodity economy* and the introduction of firearms subsequently destabilized the pure feudal structure within the timespan of a few generations. The Shokuhō regime capitalized on this momentum, actualizing the transition toward an *early modern society* (近世社会) at an astronomically rapid pace, thereby identically composing the historical legends relished by subsequent generations.

Manorial economy (庄园经济): No different from the definition universally used in academia.

Feudal political system (封建政治制度): The political system (spontaneously) organized after the feudal landlord class obtains political ruling power, based on the feudal economic system, using the High Middle Ages in England, France, and Germany as the standard. Its greatest characteristic is a distinctly hierarchical feudal power system, encompassing a series of rights and obligations; in particular, land ownership and relations of fealty possess a hereditary nature. Within the feudal system exists a military aristocracy acting as the middle and lower strata of the ruling class, translated as knights or samurai, whose maintenance of social status relies on military service.

It should be noted that the above two concepts use the High Feudal period as a standard. Feudal societies worldwide lasted for as short as four to five hundred years, or as long as over a millennium; obviously, there exists a process of development. For example, as already mentioned in the Beijing Section, judging from the situation of property inheritance systems, the entire feudal period witnessed a transition from partible inheritance to primogeniture. Therefore, under the premise of adhering to principles, actual judgments must also be analyzed in conjunction with specific circumstances. From a relatively broader perspective, under the condition where land is the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素), any society where the landlord class emerges as the ruling class, completely obtains political dominance, and can enforce its will, belongs to a feudal society.

Quasi-feudal system (准封建制度): A political system that possesses characteristics of a feudal political system to a certain degree but has not reached the standards of a feudal political system, taking the Iqta system of the Islamic world and its various local variations as examples.

Feudal society (封建社会): A society that implements the feudal economic system and the feudal political system. The reason why it is only necessary to mention the two aspects of economy and politics is simply that as long as these two aspects are realized, all other factors will spontaneously adapt or emerge.

Feudal characteristics (封建特征): The characteristics in the economic, political, military, religious, and cultural fields possessed by a feudal society. The main content is precisely found within the feudal economic system and the feudal political system.

Feudal period (封建时期): The historical period during which feudal society exists.

Feudalism (封建主义): Although the word "ism" in China is heavily biased towards ideology and economic relations, when I mention feudalism, it refers to the collection of all characteristics of a feudal society, including economic systems, political systems, military service systems, prevailing religions, social concepts, and so on.

Feudalization (封建化): This concept is used by me to describe the entire process of the evolution of a feudal society; it emphasizes a trend of change.

Degree of Feudalization (封建化程度): We can analyze the degree of feudalization of a society from two distinct dimensions. At the **macro level**, it can be measured by the degree of dominance that land, acting as the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素), exerts over the relations of production, social structure, political organization, and ideology. The higher the degree of land's dominance, the higher the degree of feudalization. At the **micro level**, it can be measured by the decisive significance that the ownership of land (*as a means of production*) holds for basic social units—like individuals and families—in acquiring social status and political rights. The greater the decisiveness of land, the higher the degree of feudalization.

When we refer to "*feudalization*," we absolutely do not employ the ambiguous concept of "the enfeoffment system" (分封制) commonly used in traditional Chinese historiography, nor do we merely oversimplify it using the "lord-vassal system" (封君封臣制) of Western European history.

In layman's terms: the more a society's economic production relies on land, the more its power structure is built around land, the more it relies on local land control to actualize political organization, and the more it depends on land to sustain its military, identity, rights, and hierarchy—the higher its degree of feudalization. Conversely, a *commodity economy*, a *bureaucratic state* (官僚机器), circulating capital, and a surplus labor force will all suppress the decisive status of land within society, signifying a decline in the degree of feudalization.

A frequently cited example here is the *daimyo* (大名) of Japan's Sengoku period. Because Japan formally retained the *Lü-ling* (律令制 / Statutory) official ranks during its process of feudalization, the dominant role of land was vividly manifested. People often ask: Why was Japan in the late Sengoku period already an unquestionable *feudal society*? Because in that era, a *daimyo* possessing a territory of 500,000 *koku* (石) would almost certainly receive a higher official rank from the Imperial Court than a *daimyo* with 50,000 *koku*. Kinoshita Tōkichirō (木下藤吉郎 / Toyotomi Hideyoshi) came from abject poverty, yet after pacifying the realm, he was able to secure the position of *Kampaku* (关白 / Imperial Regent) and the clan name "Toyotomi no Ason." The Matsudaira clan was originally an obscure local landholder, but after Tokugawa Ieyasu was appointed *Sei-i Taishōgun*, no one dared to publicly question his status as the "Chōja (Head) of the Minamoto clan." It is precisely because the Imperial Court's official ranks had been reduced to mere

decorative embellishments reflecting the *daimyos'* actual strength based on land ownership, that we can assert the Japanese samurai ultimately accomplished the monumental feat of *feudalization*.

How, then, do we distinguish between the "*ebb tide*" of *feudalization* (封建化的退潮) and the natural evolution from a *feudal society* toward a *capitalist society*? The key lies in this: when the importance of land begins to decline in both public and private spheres, *is it capital that succeeds the status of land and begins to assume its original functions?*

For instance, if we compare 17th-century the Netherlands with 14th-century northern India, it is highly likely that land was far more decisive in the latter. However, we absolutely cannot say that "the degree of feudalization of 17th-century the Netherlands was lower than that of 14th-century northern India." This is because 17th-century the Netherlands had already exited the *feudal society* and was moving toward a *capitalist society* in accordance with its normal historical progression.

Conversely, if the status of land declines, but what becomes increasingly important in determining social distribution is primary labor (初级劳动力) or bureaucratic power, then this signifies that *feudalization* experienced an *ebb tide* before it was completed! The completion of *feudalization* means that land hands over its original "scepter of power" strictly to capital, and absolutely nothing else.

Therefore, when discussing the history of Islam in this text, the emphasis is placed on Islam's capacity to effectively conquer *pre-feudal* regions. Examples include irrigated regions along major rivers, areas with highly developed urban commercial networks, regions where *classical society* had not yet vanished, *early states* or *pre-state societies*, and regions where *feudalization* was extremely weak. In these places, land had not yet thoroughly dominated the social structure; they lacked stable feudal communities, deeply rooted local armed forces, and a feudal religion profoundly intertwined with society.

As for nations that had already completed their feudal processes, although land no longer dominated the social structure as it did in the Middle Ages, the organizational and cultural legacies forged by the *feudal society* remained. These legacies would swiftly translate into *productive forces*, state capacity, and especially military might—which were certainly not something Islamic conquerors could easily shake.

The speed of *feudalization* and the maximum degree of *feudalization* achievable by a region's society are inevitably constrained by its natural geographical conditions; this is a reality no one can circumvent. In eras when humanity's capacity to transform nature was still insufficient, the geographical environment indeed exerted a colossal, sometimes even decisive, impact on human society.

Finally, I would like to clarify: *Why, when determining the degree of feudalization, must we consider the micro level in addition to the macro level?* I have two considerations here.

First, starting from the inherent characteristics of historical research itself: the vast majority of historical materials are heavily influenced by the author's own experiences, making macro-trends relatively difficult to grasp accurately, whereas evidence at the micro level is much more direct. Furthermore, from the perspective of researching the history of social life, historical data does not necessarily have to be sourced exclusively from traditional historical records. Literary works, contract documents, and other textual materials—even non-textual artifacts—can provide massive

amounts of information. This is exactly akin to how this manuscript utilizes *Dream of the Red Chamber* to reveal the social panorama of Late Imperial China.

Second, the constraints at the micro level can effectively eliminate the interference of *scarcity relations* (稀缺性关系) on macro-level judgments.

Take the Third Dynasty of Ur (乌尔第三王朝), which we discussed in the manuscript, as an example. Long before *feudalization* even began, it was indeed possible for a society to exhibit a pronounced high *land-labor ratio* (人多地少), causing the importance of land to abnormally spike, even eclipsing that of primary labor.

However, we pointed out that the changes in social distribution brought about by scarcity typically enhance the dominant role of *state power* in distribution, rather than enhancing the dominant role of the relatively scarce factor of production itself. This is because, under natural conditions, scarcity cannot emerge instantaneously. During the process of forming the final state of an extreme *land-labor ratio*, the government can utilize its state power to strengthen its monopoly over land.

Therefore, in a *land-labor pseudo-classical state* (人地型伪古典国家) like the Third Dynasty of Ur, although land appeared to occupy a highly crucial position in the social structure, for its citizens, the social status and political rights they could possess were primarily determined by their position within the Ur bureaucracy! This also proves that the Third Dynasty of Ur can by no means be considered a true classical state.

Only when the quantities of various factors of production are relatively balanced, and can be fully translated into *productive forces* under the current technological level, can one most clearly and unambiguously determine which factor of production has secured the primary position.

The definition of *feudalization* could potentially be generalized to class societies in other stages. However, because the *feudal period* is the focal point of this text, and research on *early states* and *capitalist societies* occupies a secondary position, I will not extend the discussion further here.

Feudal landlord class (封建地主阶级): The ruling class in the feudal economic system, being the controllers of the means of production and the dominators of social production. However, when I use the concept of the feudal landlord class, it solely refers to the situation where it has failed to obtain political ruling power, such as in China during the *restoration-bureaucratic period* (复辟官僚时期) .

Fascinatingly enough, within the classical definitions of Marxist historiography and political economy, the articulation of the concept of the "*feudal landlord class* (封建地主阶级)" is actually phenomenally precise: it refers to the ruling class within a *feudal society* (封建社会) (or a semi-colonial, semi-feudal society) that monopolizes land ownership and, predicated upon this foundation, exploits peasants (tenant farmers) via land rent, usury, or extra-economic coercion (personal dependency relations). The land rent mentioned here naturally encompasses the corvée rent exacted under the medieval manorial economy. In summary, the *feudal landlord class* is precisely the entity that dominates social production predicated upon the possession and utilization

of land; it is the ruling class within the relations of production formed when land occupies the unassailable position of the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素).

Feudal lord (封建领主): The feudal landlord class that has obtained ruling power politically; I mainly use this concept in feudal Europe and Japan.

Land ownership in the feudal period (封建时期的土地所有权): No matter what, even in typical feudal societies like Western Europe and Japan, the "land ownership" possessed by feudal lords could never be entirely identical to land ownership in the modern sense; nor could the legal concepts of pre-modern societies be as clear and perfected as those of modern societies. After all, a complete historical stage—the *early modern period* (近世)—separates feudal society from modern society, and the complexity of contemporary human society is entirely unimaginable compared to any previous historical period. Ultimately, the ownership of land by medieval feudal lords was still a type of *usufruct* (用益权) carrying attached obligations. If it were understood as an absolute right of disposal (绝对的支配权), then even the political phenomenon of multi-tiered subinfeudation (层层分封) would be difficult to explain. When we speak of "feudal lords acquiring land ownership," it actually refers to the fact that feudal lords possessed highly comprehensive powers of management and disposal over their land, such as collecting land rent, exacting corvée labor, exercising judicial power, administrative management, military command, gifting land, inheriting land, and enfeoffing subordinate lords. Most importantly, this power was universally recognized by the entire society and protected by statutory or customary law; it was absolutely not something that could be easily arbitrarily deprived. Thus, we are able to sufficiently distinguish the feudal lords of Europe and Japan—who practically governed their hereditary fiefdoms and could enfeoff subordinate lords—from the military aristocracy of the Islamic world, who merely obtained land revenue rights or tax collection rights as compensation for military service.

Primary factor of production (首位生产要素): Refers to the one factor that holds the primary position among all factors of production. The specific concept is detailed in Chapter 6, Section 4.

The main text mentions three dimensions for determining the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素), which constitute the sufficient conditions for becoming a *primary factor of production*. However, I wish to particularly emphasize a point here: if a certain factor of production (which may concurrently be a means of production) desires to acquire the primary position, then it must possess at least some form of irreproducibility (不可复制性).

Let us ponder an interesting question. In the agricultural age, people toiling on the land required agricultural implements and livestock. In the capitalist era, traders on the stock exchange require computers and software. Since the advent of human labor and production, humanity has never been able to divorce itself from the assistance of production tools; production tools undoubtedly belong to the category of the means of production. But why exactly is it phenomenally difficult for production tools themselves to become the *primary factor of production*? Or, taking a step further, why can tools generally not determine the social organizational structure?

The answer is: tools generally possess a high degree of reproducibility; they are frequently capable of proliferation. This generates a consequence: individuals possessing social status and power can effortlessly acquire a massive quantity of production tools, rather than individuals possessing a massive quantity of production tools being able to effortlessly acquire social status and power. This exhibits a colossal disparity compared to irreplaceable, non-renewable means of production like land: agricultural implements can be manufactured in batches, and if broken, they can be re-forged, but land cannot. If an individual does not inherently occupy land, then no matter how many agricultural implements and plow oxen they possess, it is entirely in vain. Therefore, instrumental means of production themselves are generally highly unlikely to forge social relations dominating others; they are predominantly merely the medium through which existing social relations are realized and expanded.

A special case involved within the content of this manuscript is the large-scale irrigation systems in arid regions along major rivers. As a public means of production possessing the nature of infrastructure and explicit spatial attributes, it is diametrically distinct from production tools like agricultural implements and computers that can be carried home. Large-scale irrigation systems possess obvious irreproducibility and spatial attributes, and endow land with productive value; therefore, they begin to acquire the nature of land and can become a formidable force in shaping social relations. Therefore, the text states that the importance of irrigation systems has already been capable of conspicuously suppressing the primary position of land among all factors of production; this is precisely why irrigation agriculture along major rivers can generate an obvious impediment to *feudalization* (封建化).

This is precisely why, in the short piece independent of this manuscript titled *Thoughts on the Future* (《对未来的思考》), I mentioned that the rise of AI could potentially enable *Minzhi* / *The people's intellectual and emotional capacity* (民智) to become the *primary factor of production*, rather than Artificial Intelligence itself becoming the *primary factor of production*. Because as it currently appears, AI remains merely a tool; fundamentally, zero obstacles exist to its replication and free acquisition. Identical to myriad production tools of the past, it universally lacks the capacity to allocate other means of production. AI servers cannot determine to whom knowledge belongs; they can merely augment the efficiency of acquiring knowledge. It still merely amplifies the *relations of production* (生产关系), rather than determining the *relations of production*, and consequently, it cannot become the core determining the mode of social organization. Conversely, AI indeed harbors the potential, as a production tool of a new era, to hoist humanity's "irreplaceable creative intelligence" (不可替代的创造性智能) to the position of the *primary factor of production*.

Furthermore, we can also observe the exceptionality of *capitalism* (资本主义). Recall the *primary factors of production* (首位生产要素) that have sequentially emerged thus far: primary labor power (初级劳动力) is naturally irreproducible (不可复制性), or to put it somewhat facetiously, the growth of labor power is inherently generated by labor power itself (through reproductive behavior); land is material, possesses explicit spatial attributes, and possesses phenomenally explicit irreproducibility. By contrast, capital (资本) is vastly more exceptional. Exactly as Karl Marx (马克

思) articulated, capital is a type of social relation (社会关系). Regarding its superficial physical morphology, capital is not merely reproducible, but could identically be astronomically in surplus. For instance, paper currency itself can be printed infinitely, and technically, there is zero issue regarding exactly how many copies of an existing production line are replicated. This characteristic identically constitutes one of the cornerstones of the glorious achievements of *capitalism*, namely shattering the physical limitations of land and creating unprecedented material wealth. Conversely, the irreproducibility of capital is concentratedly manifested in the "exclusive barriers" [排他性壁垒] forged upon social relations, encompassing legal monopolies (such as patents and intellectual property rights), economic monopolies (such as capital thresholds), market monopolies (such as branding, network effects, and data hegemony), and ultimately culminating in the concentration of power. Thus, we perceive two pivotal characteristics regarding the irreproducibility of capital:

First, the irreproducibility of capital, unlike the irreproducibility of land, does not belong to the inherent characteristics of the means of production, but relies upon the *superstructure* (上层建筑) constituted by institutional and infrastructural entities alongside social ideology. This dictates that state power itself possesses the capacity to destroy its irreproducibility. Therefore, individuals can observe disparate articulations regarding this phenomenon across the globe: in a Marxist-Leninist state [马列主义国家] like the Soviet Union, people assert that "the bourgeoisie possesses weakness" (“资产阶级具有软弱性”); in the heart of *capitalism* like the United States, Elon Musk (马斯克) asserts that "it is power, not capital, that exploits" (“是权力而非资本在剥削”). Although these words cannot be entirely believed, they indeed reflect a salient characteristic of *capitalism*: namely, capital is embedded within social organization and power structures, and its independence is vastly inferior to that of land. Therefore, the state apparatus possesses the capacity to infringe upon the irreproducibility of capital via *despotic power* (专制性权力), thereby suppressing the dominant position of capital within production. Therefore, the reason people feel that within a *capitalist society* (资本主义社会), the expansion of state power is more difficult to be checked and balanced by the ruling class (统治阶级), is fundamentally not entirely merely the consequence of the massive augmentation in societal complexity and the subsequent expansion of state institutions. This identically constitutes the rationale why I warned in the manuscript that even developed countries absolutely must not presume that because democratic systems have been implemented for a protracted duration, they can apathetically disregard the threat of the *restoration-bureaucratic system* (复辟官僚制度).

Second, a substantial fraction of the *superstructure* that guarantees capital possesses irreproducibility is the exact fruit borne by a complete *feudalization* (封建化) process. For instance, regarding the recognition and protection of patents and intellectual property, and even the social concepts concerning the limitation and checking of state power, from a pragmatic perspective, it is phenomenally difficult for nations that have not experienced a complete *feudal society* (封建社会) to acquire them. This consequently forges a phenomenally bizarre predicament: multitudinous

factors capable of ensuring capital acts as a stable *primary factor of production* (and subsequently maintaining a *capitalist society*), inherently sprouted precisely from within the *feudal society*. This exposes the decisive distinction between capital and land: the inherent attributes of land are fundamentally not altered by social organization and power structures. Thus, we can observe that regions like Western Europe that experienced a *classical society* (古典社会) were capable of *feudalization*; regions like Central Europe and Northern Europe that fundamentally never experienced a *classical society* were identically capable of *feudalization*, because the nature of land fundamentally does not care in the slightest whether the society previously experienced a *classical society*. However, capital does care whether the society previously experienced a *feudal society*, because it is precisely the monumental legacy of the *feudal society* that enables capital to securely occupy the throne of the *primary factor of production*, commanding the society to organize around capital, and establishing a stable *capitalist society*. This de facto forms a "Great Filter" [大过滤器] of civilization, once again corroborating the thesis of this manuscript: namely, the *feudal period* (封建时期) occupies an unshakable, central position within human civilization.

Naturally, exactly as this manuscript has persistently emphasized, the author himself has fundamentally never witnessed a genuine *capitalist society*; therefore, regarding multitudinous perspectives on *capitalism*, one can exclusively predicate them upon speculation. The cognition of *capitalism* is naturally phenomenally difficult to mention in the same breath as the citizens of developed countries, and consequently, I shall not delve into further research.

Scarcity relations (稀缺性关系): Refers to the quantitative contrast among various factors of production based on supply and demand. The status of a deficient factor of production increases, while the status of a surplus factor of production decreases. Scarcity relations do not directly act upon productive forces, but they exert an impact on the mode of production. The most universally manifested scarcity relation in human history is the *land-labor ratio* (人地关系), namely the relative abundance or shortage of labor and land. When all factors of production can be fully converted into productive forces under existing technological levels, it can be considered that the factors of production are in a state of relative equilibrium—none is obviously in surplus, and none is obviously in shortage.

Commodity economy and Natural economy (商品经济和自然经济): No different from the definitions used in academia.

A question will likely arise: is the rise of the *natural economy* (自然经济) the cause of *feudalization* (封建化), or its consequence?

My view is that many major phenomena in history can never be viewed merely as unidirectional causal relationships; rather, multiple variables may mutually reinforce each other, ultimately entering a new state of equilibrium. The root cause of the *natural economy* gaining dominance over a certain period lies in the fact that *productive forces* (生产力) had developed to such a stage where self-sufficient production surpassed commodity circulation (which entails costs) in terms of comprehensive returns (including risk factors). This is not inconceivable. From the classical period

to the *feudal period* (封建时期), the growth of *productive forces* was limited. Humanity remained in an agricultural society, and the complexity of the social division of labor had not undergone a fundamental change; thus, it was indeed possible for a large *manor* (庄园) to fulfill the vast majority of production needs. The *natural economy* could gain the upper hand not because *productive forces* were low, but because, during the development of *productive forces*, the production system was still simple enough to allow the *natural economy* to become advantageous. After the Industrial Revolution, even with the rapid development of *productive forces*, it became impossible to return to that self-sufficient economic model, because the modern production system has become so complex that nowhere can independently complete the entirety of production.

Therefore, the rise of the *natural economy* is an important driving factor for *feudalization*, especially since this process enhanced the status of land among various factors of production. Conversely, however, the *feudalization* process was also further strengthening the *natural economy*. When the landlord class considered that, under their current conditions of *productive forces*, the *natural economy* was economically more efficient than a *commodity economy* (商品经济) relying on exchange networks, they would naturally respond. If a large number of producers began to reduce their market participation, the empire's tax revenues would decline, cities would decay, the number of merchants would decrease, currency circulation would shrink, and road maintenance would deteriorate. Consequently, circulation costs would further increase, prompting even more producers to exit the market. The *natural economy* and the *feudalization* process began to mutually promote each other.

Of course, readers still need to be reminded that the phrase "the rise of the *natural economy*" is certainly not as reasonable as "the *natural economy* becoming the most economically efficient." As we mentioned earlier, many so-called "*feudal characteristics*" (封建特征) are essentially derived from a contrast with previous "*classical characteristics*" (古典特征). For regions within Rome, Northern India, and China that experienced the zenith of classical empires, they had periods of highly prosperous *commodity economies*, during which the returns of specialized production far outweighed transportation costs. Therefore, when *productive forces* developed to a certain stage, one could observe in these regions that the *natural economy* began to universally replace the *commodity economy* as the dominant economic model. However, for those regions that began *feudalization* without having experienced a classical era, the idea of "the further development of the *natural economy*" seems quite peculiar. For many parts of Northern and Eastern Europe, it is hard to say that there was any developed *commodity economy* to die out before overt *feudalization* occurred. During the *feudalization* process of these regions, not only was the *natural economy* developing, but the *commodity economy* was also highly likely developing. The reason is simply that they were too backward previously.

Even considering this from an economic perspective, in the early stage of *feudalization* (封建化), the initial development of the *natural economy* (自然经济) did not necessarily require that self-sufficient land production hold an absolute efficiency advantage over circulation and exchange; it is highly likely that it was sufficient for the former to merely approach the latter in efficiency. The reason lies in the fact that when people make economic decisions, they never solely consider

expected returns; rather, they seriously evaluate risk-adjusted efficiency, particularly whether such risks can be controlled, to some extent, in their own hands. Let us take a classic problem as an example: suppose there are four investment methods, A, B, C, and D, and long-term statistics show a clear magnitude relationship in their expected returns. However, even an astute financial expert would not necessarily allocate all funds into the investment method with the highest expected return, because a high expected return may also entail staggering risks. Ultimately, people will most likely choose a diversified composite investment portfolio. If we conduct random interviews on the street, given one option with a 50% chance of gaining 100 million yuan and a 50% chance of losing 5 million yuan, and another option with a 100% chance of gaining 10 million yuan. The expected return of the former is certainly higher than that of the latter, yet it is highly likely that the vast majority of people would choose the second option!

Human society in the agricultural age was far more fragile than it is today; even land managers could not possibly focus solely on maximizing expected values while ignoring survival probabilities. They had to prioritize the resilience of their production mode, rather than merely pursuing efficiency rigidly. In a society relying on complex circulation networks, land managers had to acknowledge that many risks lay in the hands of regions and actors beyond their control.

Although conducting self-sufficient agriculture on a *manor* (庄园) also depended on the weather, this at least provided the managers with a sense of security that they were still in control of the situation. It is much like how people today know that taking an airplane is not necessarily more dangerous than riding in a car, but why are there far more people who fear flying than those who fear driving? A particularly crucial reason is that, in the event of any accident on an airplane, passengers have almost no possibility of responding themselves; the vast majority of their fate must be surrendered to the heavens, with a minuscule fraction relying mainly on the pilot.

Furthermore, we have indeed seen major historical events such as the Late Bronze Age collapse. It most likely began with agricultural failures, natural disasters, and social crises in a single region. But what might have happened immediately afterward? The tin trade was obstructed, bronze production shrank, armies could not be maintained, social order became even more chaotic, trade routes became more dangerous, and then trade shrank even further. The failure of a few critical nodes was sufficient to trigger a cascading, systemic collapse of a complex international system highly dependent on long-distance trade. Of course, we are not suggesting that people in the late period of classical empires knew about the Late Bronze Age collapse; it is almost impossible that they did. However, we must not assume that the ancients were intellectually inferior to modern people; the ancients were fully capable of rationally considering risks and making decisions.

Therefore, it is entirely plausible that even if self-sufficient production had not yet completely surpassed the *commodity economy* (商品经济)—which still existed in the late period of classical empires—in terms of efficiency, there would still be some managers who seriously considered attempting to transition to a *natural economy* model. And once the proportion of the *natural economy* increased, the demand for the market would weaken; the reduction in circulation volume would drive up unit transportation costs, which would stimulate more landlords to shift toward self-sufficient production, subsequently causing the scale of trade to shrink even further. That is to say, there exists a threshold determined by the returns and risks of the *natural economy* and the *commodity economy*. Once the relative advantage of the *natural economy* reaches this threshold, it triggers a positive feedback loop, thereby propelling the unstoppable rise of the *natural economy*.

More importantly, the late period of classical empires would indeed generate certain risk-structure changes conducive to lowering this threshold, the sources of which were relatively independent of the development of the imperial society itself. For instance, the *barbarians* (蛮族) on the empire's frontiers would also undergo significant social progress during their long-term contact with the empire, posing an ever-growing threat to the imperial borders (certain sporadic migratory behaviors further intensified this threat). Consequently, during its late period, the classical empire had to face more wars it was forced to fight; the tax burden rose, the bureaucratic system (as in Rome) became more complex, and the state even actively debased its currency. We can also consider the climatic fluctuations detrimental to the empire mentioned by some scholars. In summary, during its late period, a classical empire would encounter numerous factors that drove up the costs and risks of commercial circulation; this further weakened the competitiveness of the *commodity economy* and greatly facilitated the development of the *natural economy*.

Slavery society (奴隶制社会): Any society where the phenomenon of exploitation exists, and where the direct exploitation of the exploited's labor power through bodily possession (人身占有) and forced labor dominates the forms of exploitation (in terms of proportion within economic activities), can be called a slavery society. A slavery society does not necessarily mean that the vast majority of the population are slaves; it is even possible that the majority of the population are not slaves.

Similarly, a society that exists with or even permits the institution of slavery cannot necessarily be termed a slavery society—such as the European countries that participated in the triangular trade. Furthermore, those who are directly exploited for their primary labor power to a certain extent might not necessarily be legally categorized as slaves in their identity; for instance, some free citizens were also subjected to mandatory forced labor by the state.

This revision helps resolve the situation where evaluations of slavery societies vary wildly across different regions of the world, we should point out that this new definition possesses a certain degree of rationality. The reason lies in the fact that, under the relatively backward conditions of productive forces in early states, economic exploitation was indeed the primary method for collecting and utilizing the *social surplus* (社会剩余), and the ultimate destination of this social surplus directly determines the evolutionary direction of the society. Therefore, if we ignore those fruits of social labor production that cannot be effectively invested due to insufficient quantity and excessive dispersion, and instead focus our observation on the portion that could be executed as effective investment, then the definition of a "slavery society" does indeed reflect the true nature of early states.

Early state (早期国家): This concept is even more ambiguous. My view is that any state that has reached the form of a state, but is clearly in a *pre-classical* and *pre-feudal* state (the reason for emphasizing pre-feudal is that we have already seen some regions bypass the classical period and directly undergo *feudalization*), are collectively referred to as early states. I hold this view even if it means classifying some seemingly quite mature and complex states (such as Egypt during the New Kingdom period) as early states. Among the modes of exploitation existing in early states, slavery occupied the main body, and kinship (血缘) still held an important position in the state's political

organization. The territory an early state could control was highly limited; its rule relied heavily on cities (city-states) as strongholds of domination, and it was heavily restricted by the natural environment.

Old nobility (旧贵族): This term carries the characteristics of communist nations; when I use it, it refers to the ruling class in early states. Evolving from clan chieftains, religious priests, and military leaders, they were historically viewed as possessing nobility of bloodline. The foundation of the old nobility's rule lay in their monopoly over the factors of production, with *knowledge* being particularly worthy of attention. The old nobility frequently possessed the identity of slave owners simultaneously.

Tribal group (部族): This concept is also quite ambiguous and it is basically impossible to reach any consensus. When I use it, it refers to the aggregate of all tribes (部落) within a certain geographical scope, where territorial identity has, to a certain extent, transcended blood relations, and a kind of common consciousness based on culture and language has emerged. A tribal group is generally still in the pre-state stage, but in some circumstances, it may be viewed as an early state, depending on internationally recognized standards.

Tribal confederacy (部族联盟): A political entity formed by tribal groups, encompassing a large number of tribes. The difference from a simple tribal alliance (部落联盟) lies in the fact that when I use the term tribal confederacy, I emphasize the stability of leadership succession; the ruler of a tribal confederacy is no longer produced through election by various tribes, but remains within one tribe for a long period and possesses a hereditary nature.

Community (社群): No different from the universal standard used in academia, though I may use it less strictly, sometimes appearing as an abbreviation for "social groups" (社会群体).

Civilization (文明): Although it is unlikely that everyone will reach a consensus on the definition of this concept, when I use it, there is no difference from international universal standards.

Country / State (国家): What is the precise definition of a state? Which regimes in history count as states? This is obviously another issue where consensus is impossible to achieve, but when I use it, there is no difference from international universal standards.

International universal standard (国际通用标准): When I refer to following "international universal standards" for certain concepts where consensus is difficult to reach, I mean the following principle. Assuming that for a particular element, the vast majority of scholars in the world believe it should belong to a certain set, then I will also consider that element to belong to this set. If the vast majority of scholars worldwide believe this element does not belong to the set, then I will also consider it not to belong to the set. For instance, regarding universally recognized states or civilizations, I will certainly view them as states or civilizations; however, for regimes universally acknowledged as not having met the standard of a state, or cultures not having met the standard of a civilization, I will likewise not view them as states or civilizations.

Bureaucratic state (官僚国家): Of course, one cannot say that any state possessing some form of bureaucratic system is a bureaucratic state; apart from rather primitive early states (早期国家), all states possess bureaucratic systems of varying complexity and divergent purposes. When I use the term "bureaucratic state," it absolutely indicates that the state's bureaucratic system plays a decisive role in the allocation of social resources (including the tangible, such as land and gold/silver, as well as the intangible, such as authority and information) and the determination of social status. In other words, the destiny of an individual or a family relies highly on their position within the bureaucracy, having no direct relationship with any other factors. It is not the case that a person attains a high position within the bureaucracy because they possess immense wealth, lofty social status, universally known prestige, or play a vital role in social production; rather, it is precisely because of their high position within the bureaucracy that all the aforementioned things can be easily acquired. The bureaucratic system of a normal state is constrained by various social forces, whereas the society of a bureaucratic state revolves around the bureaucratic system. Historically speaking, a *powerful coalition of class interests* (阶级利益共同体) is the primary force preventing the emergence of a bureaucratic state. Within a bureaucratic state, there does not exist a broadly recognized class alliance with unified core interests and formidable political power.

Governance-oriented bureaucratic system (治理型官僚制度): The most common bureaucratic system. Its primary purpose is to maintain the normal operation of the existing society. The governance nature of the bureaucratic system primarily reflects the state's capability to actually intervene in social life and effectively implement political decisions; it is mainly related to *infrastructural power* (基础性权力).

Predatory bureaucratic system (掠夺型官僚制度): I sometimes also refer to it as an *extractive bureaucratic system* (榨取型官僚制度); it is a type of bureaucratic system that may emerge during prolonged wars or military confrontations. Its primary goal is to efficiently and thoroughly extort the entire *social surplus* (社会剩余), even potentially committing acts tantamount to killing the goose that lays the golden eggs. Under certain circumstances, the massive wealth extracted by this bureaucracy can be channeled into effective investments, but in the vast majority of cases, it fundamentally amounts to "extracting every single ounce of wealth only to squander it like dirt." The predatory nature of the bureaucratic system primarily reflects the state regime's capability to destroy social conventions and disregard the will of various social groups; it is mainly related to *despotic power* (专制性权力). States operating under a centrally commanded planned economy under Bolshevik rule in the 20th century can, in some circumstances, be viewed as predatory bureaucratic states, such as the Soviet Union in the 1930s.

Asphyxiating bureaucratic system (窒息型官僚制度): Or termed an *oppressive bureaucratic system* (压迫型官僚制度). Its primary purpose is to eliminate, regardless of cost, any factors that might cause a change in the social status quo. To achieve its purpose, this bureaucratic system may require a massive secret police apparatus and thus become a police state. However, soft methods

can equally achieve the goal of obliterating culture; the *restoration-bureaucratic states* (复辟官僚国家) of the Ming and Qing dynasties essentially accomplished this, though it required the long-term domestication of the people. The asphyxiating nature of the bureaucratic system has a certain degree of requirement for both despotic power and infrastructural power.

Asphyxiating bureaucratic states generally exhibit relatively obvious predatory traits; the characteristic distinguishing them from predatory bureaucratic states is that the latter's purpose in plundering social wealth lies in making some sort of investment (including military purposes). Yet, in many cases, due to the deceptive nature of political propaganda, it is difficult for people to fully distinguish whether the fundamental purpose of certain government investments is precisely to "weaken the people" (弱民)—for example, the massive war-preparation movements in China and Albania during the latter half of the 20th century. When making the distinction, I basically judge by the results rather than the propaganda; unless the investments made by the government using the people's hard-earned wealth genuinely yield substantial returns, only then will I say this bureaucratic system is a predatory one.

Social surplus (社会剩余): When I use this term, it refers to the resources, wealth, time, or capabilities that remain in a society after the basic survival needs of all its members have been met.

Surplus of social production (社会生产剩余): Although some might question why I define two very similar concepts, there is indeed a distinction when I use them. When I use the concept of the *surplus of social production*, it refers to the surplus resources, wealth, time, or capabilities created by the labor of the entire society, beyond what is necessary to maintain the existing existence of the society. The cost of "maintaining the existing existence of the society" is obviously not lower than "meeting the basic survival needs of all members," because investments are required in various aspects such as administration, religion, circulation, and the military. Therefore, for the same society, unless it is exceedingly primitive, its *surplus of social production* is distinctly less than its *social surplus*.

Social efficiency (社会效率): Refers to the proportion of the *social surplus* that is utilized for *expanded reproduction* (扩大再生产), investment in science, education, literature, and art, improvement of public services and welfare, advancement of humanitarian causes, and promotion of consumption.

Historical sequence (历史序列): Namely, the evolutionary sequence of human society. It sequentially comprises six historical stages: pre-state society, early state, classical society, feudal society, early modern society, and modern society. Not every nation is obliged to experience, or rather, has the fortune to experience all the stages up to the present. Likewise, many states in history cannot be categorized into any single one of these stages; however, we can absolutely use this historical sequence as a basis to position the regimes in ancient human history. For a country like China that completely detached from the historical sequence, I sometimes refer to it as a "*derailed state*" (脱轨国家), to indicate that it completely deviated from the normal developmental track of human society.

Here, we shall further supplement the explanation regarding the scale of the object of historical research. That is to say, when we study how the society of a certain region changes along the **historical sequence** (历史序列), what kind of research object is exactly considered a "legitimate" one?

Having read the entire manuscript, readers presumably have an answer as to what kind of spatial unit qualifies as an independent object of historical evolution: namely, whether this society can, over a relatively long period, primarily rely on its own internal mechanisms to complete the evolution of its institutions, **class** (阶级), culture, and economic structure.

Generally speaking, for a society situated in an open world to meet the standard of independent evolution, its social scale must be sufficiently large; otherwise, the reconfiguration of its social structure and the evolution of its institutions would be primarily dominated by external systems, rather than relying mainly on its own internal forces. Conversely, a geographically extremely isolated society, even if its scale is very small, might still be considered a legitimate object of independent evolution.

For instance, a certain principality of the Holy Roman Empire might have a population of several hundred thousand and an area of several thousand square kilometers, but its trade system is attached to the empire, its religious system is attached to the church, its military system is attached to a larger political community, and its technological diffusion comes from the entirety of Western Europe; under no circumstances could it achieve independent evolution. In contrast, a certain ancient island nation in the Pacific might similarly have a small area and perhaps an even smaller population, but its social structure and production system are complete, it has extremely little external communication, and the driving force for its institutional changes comes primarily from within. **Then**, even if it is exceedingly simple, it possesses the capacity for independent evolution.

The capacity for independent evolution is not absolute; its strength and weakness exist on a continuous spectrum [连续谱]. Regions like China, India, Japan, France, and the United Kingdom have a very strong capacity for independent evolution. However, regions like Korea, Myanmar, and Northern Europe have their own evolutionary capacities, but are obviously influenced by large civilizational spheres. Meanwhile, the Holy Roman Empire and the small principalities of Italy are hardly considered to have autonomy and can essentially be regarded as subordinate to a larger system.

The interior of a larger research object still holds the possibility of subdivision; for example, the historical evolution of Northern India and Southern India are not entirely identical. Some regions can be considered independent units for a period of time, but are later swallowed by a larger system and thus lose their capacity for independent evolution, such as Yunnan. Some regions have their capacity for independent evolution strengthened due to political independence, such as Vietnam. The independent evolution of some regions is interrupted by external forces and **then** restarts from a new position, such as Latin America. In the Near East (近东), many regions changed hands repeatedly, and their independent evolutionary processes were jointly influenced by various civilizational spheres.

With the decisive rise of the Western world in the 17th and 18th centuries, it exerted an exceedingly intense influence on the entire world. Even regions that previously had very strong evolutionary independence, such as India and China, also suffered the shockwaves.

In conclusion, an independent object of historical research refers to a community whose social structural evolution is primarily determined by internal dynamics, rather than by external systems.

The Great Expansion (大扩张): Refers to the long-term process wherein, supported by crucial technologies represented by the use of iron tools, the capability of certain *tribal groups* (部族) to transform nature was massively enhanced, which in turn drastically expanded the scope of civilization through large-scale conquests, and rapidly developed societies possessing early-state levels in the conquered regions. This historical phenomenon was particularly prominent during the last millennium BCE, resulting in the formation of a batch of classical empires across the Eurasian continent. The Great Expansion created the necessary conditions for the formation of primary classical societies.

Another point worth noting is that precisely during the Great Expansion period, due to frequent wars and the relative scarcity of labor, the proportion of slaves in the total population of society was paradoxically larger than during the early state period; the stereotype people held in the past about a slavery society—that of "universally driving slaves into forced labor"—perhaps reflects more of the landscape of the Great Expansion period.

Classical characteristics (古典特征): Unprecedentedly (and perhaps never again) vast territorial expanse of the regime, formidable monarchical power, an army highly capable in warfare, a (relatively) mature bureaucratic apparatus, strong state capacity, unified weights and measures and legal codes, a (relatively) complex social structure, possessing a highly centralized large capital, simultaneous surges in the government's despotic power and infrastructural power, the use of a certain *lingua franca* (四方通语), prosperous urban life, active commodity economy, massive circulation of precious metals, open social ethos, relatively high status of women, highly inclusive social consciousness, coexistence of multiple schools of thought, state (monarch) sponsorship of large-scale academic institutions and individual scholars, prevalence of rationalism, emphasis on speculative thinking, abundant academic achievements in scientific and technological fields, the emergence of mega-engineering projects, excellent public services, and so on.

Typical classical state/empire (典型古典国家/帝国): Typical classical states are sometimes also written by me as genuine classical empires; the foundation of their establishment is the *class transition* (阶级交替) triggered during the process of land replacing labor as the primary factor of production, namely, the landlord class replacing the old nobility to become the new landlord class (although at this time the natural economy does not yet dominate). This process not only generated a massive number of *non-producing bureaucrats* (脱产官僚) but also made it difficult for the ruling class (because it was undergoing transition) to form unified interest demands, which provided conditions for the formation of the classical bureaucratic system and the strengthening of monarchical absolutism. The state capacity of typical classical states was exceptionally formidable, which implies that their infrastructural power reached the highest level prior to the early modern period. Typical classical states include the Roman Empire during the Principate, the Western Han

Empire, the Gupta Dynasty of India, the late Sasanian Empire, should include the Khmer Empire (though data is too scarce), and, in a certain sense, also includes Japan during the Insei (Cloistered Rule) period. Typical classical states will possess the vast majority of classical characteristics. Because of the robustness of their bureaucratic systems, I sometimes also refer to classical states as classical bureaucratic states.

Classical bureaucratic system (古典官僚体制): Namely, the bureaucratic system generally formed by classical bureaucratic states. The characteristics of the classical bureaucratic system lie in the complex backgrounds of its officials, the pluralism of ideologies, and the diversity of pathways to entering government service. Although the classical bureaucratic system may form a set of rules to maintain its own operation, the appointment, dismissal, promotion, and demotion of officials by the ruler based on personal needs and preferences remains the primary driving force behind the operation of the classical bureaucratic system. Compared to the bureaucratic systems of early modern and modern states, a characteristic of the classical bureaucratic system is that its official selection system is relatively rudimentary.

Primary classical state (原生古典国家): Classical states formed directly through the Great Expansion prior to the Common Era (BCE), rather than classical states formed in later periods under strong external influence; they existed exclusively in Greco-Roman, Persian, Indian, and Chinese civilizations. Based on observation, basically only primary classical states can manifest as typical classical states at a certain stage.

Formative classical state (形成期古典国家): Specifically refers to the large vassal kingdoms during the Warring States period of China. Because the process of the Great Expansion led by the Zhu Xia (various Chinese states) occurred relatively early, tribal groups and communities had already been largely eliminated in the latter half of the Great Expansion. Therefore, the germination of feudalism and the phenomenon of class transition in ancient China had already become highly evident by the late Warring States period, which became the prerequisite for the political reforms (变法) in the various vassal states, although China was not yet unified at this time.

Classical society (古典社会): The social formation possessed by *typical classical states* (典型古典国家) is classical society.

Classical period (古典时期): In a narrow sense, the classical period is the historical period during which typical classical states existed. In a broad sense, the classical period traces back to the formative period of typical classical states and extends forward to the collapse period of typical classical states. Under a looser definition, the period during which regimes exhibiting certain classical characteristics appeared in relatively backward regions is also viewed as the classical period of that region.

Late Antiquity (古典时代晚期): In accordance with the definition by Western historians.

Classical empire (古典帝国): The *classical empire* in a narrow sense is the *typical classical empire*. The standard for a broad classical empire can be flexible, but it must at least ensure that no

dislocation occurs in its historical developmental sequence. That is to say, once a certain regime is identified as a classical empire, the historical stage the local society was in before the establishment of this regime cannot be later than the classical period, and the historical stage the local society is in after the end of this regime cannot be earlier than the classical period. For example, before the Caliphate of Córdoba was established in Iberia, the Iberian Peninsula had already undergone *feudalization* (封建化); therefore, it cannot be viewed as a classical empire, but at best belongs to a kind of *late-classical empire* (晚期古典帝国). Similarly, the *restoration-bureaucratic empires* (复辟官僚帝国) do not belong to classical empires either, because northern China had already exhibited obvious *feudalization characteristics* during the Northern and Southern Dynasties. After the Songhai Empire was defeated by the Moroccans, the territory it ruled not only showed no obvious phenomenon of *feudalization*, but instead regressed to a state where a multitude of *early states* (早期国家) and even tribes stood in great numbers, and various folk religions remained prevalent; thus, it also cannot be viewed as a classical empire, but at best a highly developed early state due to its important position in the trade network. Likewise, the Xiongnu Empire cannot truly be viewed as a *classical empire*, because the Mongolian region never saw the emergence of a *classical empire* afterward, and *feudalization* did not become obvious until the late Ming Dynasty. I call this judgment principle the *principle of sequential invariance* (序位不变原则), which essentially insists on the following view: even if the so-called classical characteristics number in the thousands, the essence of the classical period is always a "transitional period" transitioning from an early state to a *feudal society* (封建社会). A universally recognized classical state should possess a certain number of classical characteristics. When I speak of classical empires, I generally refer to classical empires in the broad sense; otherwise, I will emphasize that I am speaking of genuine classical empires.

Chonggang Junfu / Towering Mountains (重冈俊阜): The literal meaning of this term in Chinese is high mountains. I use it to describe the thick filter people hold regarding the classical period and classical empires; the greatness of classical glory is excessively exaggerated, and too many unrealistic hopes are pinned upon it.

The zenith of classical empires or classical empires at their zenith (鼎盛时期的古典帝国或古典帝国的鼎盛时期): When I use this expression, it refers to the very, very literal historical period when a classical state is ostensibly at its most powerful. The only point I wish to remind the reader of is that there is a difference between the zenith of a classical empire and the historical period when classical society existed. Generally speaking, in the era when a classical empire appears most powerful, the *class transition* (阶级过渡) has basically been completed, and the *feudal mode of production* (封建生产方式) occupies the mainstream; therefore, chronologically, it is later than classical society. The reason the empire has not yet declined due to feudalization is that the degree of land annexation is still relatively low, and the feudal manors of the *natural economy* (自然经济) have not yet universally appeared.

Early classical states/empires (早期古典国家/帝国): Refers to massive empires that already exhibited many classical characteristics before their societies had developed to the classical society stage. These include the Achaemenid Empire of Persia, the Parthian Empire, the Kushan Empire (dubious), and the Maurya Dynasty. The foundation of existence for such regimes lay in the central government's control over economic circulation as well as the autonomy of local *tribal groups* (部落) and *communities* (社群).

Imported classical states (输入型古典国家): Specifically refers to a series of regimes on the periphery of China. The societies of these regimes themselves had not developed to the classical society stage, but under the influence of China, they prematurely introduced China's bureaucratic system—especially the bureaucratic system of the Tang Dynasty's restoration period (唐代复辟时期)—thus exhibiting some classical characteristics. This type of state includes Goguryeo, Baekje, Silla and Unified Silla, Japan during the Asuka and Nara periods, the state of Balhae, and Nanzhao.

Classical nomadic empire (古典游牧帝国): Refers to the Xiongnu. The Xiongnu belonged to the spillover of the historical event of the *Great Expansion* (大扩张) occurring in the East Asian nomadic regions, and therefore possessed obvious classical characteristics.

Anomalous classical state (异常古典国家): Refers to the Goryeo regime on the Korean Peninsula. This state was indeed at the stage of classical society, but it erroneously introduced China's *restoration-bureaucratic system* (复辟官僚制度).

Trade-based pseudo-classical states (贸易型伪古典国家): Refers to states whose societies were far from developing into the classical society stage, but because the region occupied a key position in international trade, they exhibited certain classical characteristics under external influence. These include Aksum, Srivijaya, the Khazar Khaganate, Mali, and Songhai. This type of state was extremely fragile and far from being a genuine classical state; once its trade status was lost or it collapsed due to military defeat, the local society would still lack signs of *feudalization* (封建化) for a very long time.

Land-labor pseudo-classical states (人地型伪古典国家): Refers to states whose societies were far from developing into the classical society stage, but because of a severe imbalance in the *land-labor ratio* (人地关系) and the highly obvious situation of limited land and a massive population, the status of primary labor as the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素) was challenged by land. Coupled with the emergence of refined production and the demand for complex cooperation, the state exhibited certain classical characteristics, especially an anomalously highly developed bureaucratic system. A representative example is the Third Dynasty of Ur. This type of state was fragile regardless of whether from institutional, environmental, or military aspects.

Late-classical states (晚期古典国家): Refers to states that, during the historical period when classical society had already ended and feudalization had become extremely obvious, still maintained partial classical characteristics, especially retaining the *classical bureaucratic system* (古典官僚体制). This type of state relied on its position in international trade and the government's control over circulation. The most typical late-classical state is the Byzantine Empire, and it should at least also include the Caliphate of Córdoba, and possibly the Pala Dynasty of Bangladesh.

Barbarians (蛮族): A collective term for the various ethnic groups that entered the core civilized regions on a massive scale during the late period of classical empires. This name does not mean that the barbarians were necessarily that backward compared to the classical empire; it merely emphasizes their identity as the "Other" (他者) relative to the classical empire. After the barbarians "entered the pass" (入关), the resulting growth in the level of productive forces gave them a massive demand to occupy land, thus making them the main force of *feudalization*.

Ru Guan / Entering the Pass (入关): This is a highly Sinicized expression, referring to the process by which a weak and small nation or faction conquers a large state through military victory.

Restoration-bureaucratic states (复辟官僚国家): Refers to a political state where, after classical society had completely ended and the *feudal economic system* (封建经济体制) had already emerged, due to the anomalously formidable bureaucratic system, the *feudal landlord class* (封建地主阶级) failed to obtain political ruling power and failed to further evolve into *feudal lords* (封建领主); the *feudalization* process was interrupted and subsequently regressed, causing the bureaucratic state to re-emerge. *Restoration-bureaucratic states* include China after the Sui and Tang dynasties, Vietnam after gaining independence from China, and the Joseon Dynasty in Korea.

The essence distinguishing *restoration-bureaucratic states* from late-classical states lies in the fact that the latter factually lacked the capability to cope with feudalization; they could only delay but not stop the impact of feudalization on the classical bureaucratic system, and still possessed a tendency towards dissolution. However, the *restoration-bureaucratic state* mastered complete political means to suppress the feudal landlord class, preventing the formation of large-scale landownership (大土地所有制), leaving the landlord class in a politically oppressed position by the bureaucratic state just like the ruled classes, and eliminating the threat of feudalization to the autocratic monarch and the bureaucratic regime. The *despotic power* (专制性权力) of the monarch anomalously surged precisely while the feudal economic system existed.

Restoration-bureaucratic system (复辟官僚制度): The bureaucratic system implemented by *restoration-bureaucratic states*, which underwent continuous changes and steady enhancement from the Tang through the Qing dynasties.

It is particularly noteworthy that many Western researchers consider the staggering waste of the *social surplus* (社会剩余) by the *restoration-bureaucratic system* to be a mere "blunder" (失策). In

reality, however, the systematic destruction of the *social surplus*—ensuring that the *surplus of social production* (社会生产剩余) is barely generated at all—is precisely the very means by which the *restoration-bureaucratic system* maintains its own existence. This is because any effectively utilized *surplus of social production* has the potential to bring about changes that the *restoration-bureaucratic system* does not wish to see, which runs completely counter to its goal of "stability maintenance" (维稳).

Nevertheless, the bureaucratic system inherently possesses the attribute of over-expansion, and this is especially true for a *restoration-bureaucratic system* operating completely unchecked by any oversight. Therefore, the *restoration-bureaucratic system* cannot manage to destroy exactly as much *social surplus* as is produced. It invariably leads to a consequence where the social wealth it destroys becomes increasingly massive, to the point where maintaining basic social public services and reproduction becomes impossible. Once it senses a crisis, the *restoration-bureaucratic system* may attempt to save itself; yet, every self-rescue attempt only renders the system itself even more bloated and more destructive. The ultimate result is that the society enters a state of total collapse, which constitutes the declining phase of the so-called "*dynastic cycle*" (王朝周期律) in Chinese history.

Ebb tide (退潮): This is a description used personally by me. It refers to the phenomenon where a social stage within a certain *historical sequence* (历史序列)—primarily feudal society, of course—begins to have its political and economic systems disintegrate before it has spontaneously evolved and moved towards the next social stage. For example, the restoration of the bureaucratic state during the Sui and Tang dynasties, or the Islamic world and India under Western influence, can all be termed an "*ebb tide of feudalization*" (封建化退潮).

Pseudo-modernization (伪近(现)代化): Refers to the phenomenon where regions that have not completely experienced the stages of *feudal society* (封建社会) and *early modern society* (近世社会) introduce—solely under the influence of the Western world—the science, technology, and certain organizations, institutions and ideologies created by major developed countries since the High Middle Ages; however, their social existence generates a fierce resistance against these overly advanced imported goods. Pseudo-modernization is extremely prevalent worldwide.

Religious doctrine (宗教教义): Religious doctrine refers to the core beliefs, fundamental principles, and worldview of a religion. Put simply, it is the religion telling people what they should believe.

Religious law (宗教教法): Religious law consists of the laws and regulations formulated based on religious doctrine to standardize the behavior of believers; it is the concretization and application of doctrine. The function of religious law is to guide the behavioral norms of believers in their daily lives, encompassing religious rituals, ethics and morality, social relations, and other aspects. Put simply, it is the religion telling people what they should do.

Classical religion (古典宗教): Religions that responded to the various demands of classical society and possessed a relatively good capacity to adapt to various types of "classical states." Typified by Mahayana Buddhism, they may include Zoroastrianism, certain branches of early Christianity, and Khmerized Hinduism, and in a certain sense also encompass Han Dynasty Confucian scholasticism (汉代经学)—though I still maintain that Confucianism does not belong to the category of religion.

Classical religions might undergo adaptive changes in *late-classical societies* (晚期古典社会); their mystic tendencies and non-public rituals would increase, and they would further deify the monarch. The most typical example is Vajrayana Buddhism, and it should simultaneously include Eastern Orthodoxy.

Feudal religion / Feudalized religion (封建宗教 / 封建化宗教): Religions capable of adapting to the requirements of the historical process of *feudalization* (封建化), playing a massive role in maintaining basic circulation and technological investment during the early stages of feudal society. Compared to classical religions, the greatest characteristic of feudal religions lies in their penetration into the grassroots of society, being oriented towards the masses, simplifying methods of cultivation, emphasizing "salvation by faith" (因信得救), and possessing highly developed churches and religious orders (教团) that actively participate in social activities. Typical feudal religions include Catholicism, Japanese Buddhism, and Theravada Buddhism; they should also include Ethiopian Orthodoxy, the majority of sects within Hinduism and Islam, and, in a certain sense, Tibetan Buddhism. However, I want to emphasize that religion is not the essential characteristic of a certain society; religion possesses strong adaptability to changes in social existence, and one should not interpret it literally or superficially when making specific judgments.

The end of feudal religion (封建宗教的结束): As a region transitions from a feudal society into an *early modern society* (近世社会), secular state apparatuses and various social organizations rapidly expand their capabilities. Early modern society, objectively speaking, no longer needs feudal religion to play the vital role in social life that it did during the Middle Ages. Due to their inherent characteristics, religions' efficiency in assisting economic circulation and technological investment is surpassed by the various newly emerging institutions of the early modern era. The influence of religion on social ideology is also not conducive to the popularization of scientific concepts throughout the entire society. Therefore, during the period when a state transitions toward the early modern era, various forms of movements opposing feudal religion inevitably emerge—from the mildest religious reformations to the most violent activities, such as Oda Nobunaga's suppression of the *Ikki* (sectarian uprisings), which can all be witnessed in history. Religions that have undergone the baptism of early-modernization will no longer be as strictly managed organizationally (including both doctrine and law) as they were in the Middle Ages, and their degree of participation in general social life significantly declines. Of course, as demonstrated by the European Reformation, new religious sects might be even stricter in their demands for moral precepts. The new sects that emerged in regions with the most developed commercial and industrial economies during the Reformation period—such as Protestant Christianity (基督新教)—can, in this sense, be termed an early modern religion.

Feudal holy war (封建圣战): Refers to wars instigated by feudal religions aimed at acquiring land and implementing the feudal system in the conquered regions, ultimately transforming the conquerors into the ruling class. The most typical feudal holy wars are the series of crusades launched by the Germans in the Baltic region starting from the High Middle Ages. Many *Jihads* launched by Islamic regimes also possessed the nature of a feudal holy war, but because the feudalization of the Islamic world was always incomplete, the results were not as typical. Not all hostile actions carrying the slogan of a religious holy war belong to feudal holy wars.

Classical *lingua franca* (古典通语): Sometimes taking the form of a classical universal script (古典通文). It refers to a spoken or written language officially recognized by a classical empire and widely used throughout the empire. During the feudal period after the end of the *classical empire*, it would still serve as the language used by the feudal religious church, until it was gradually replaced by feudal national languages.

Feudal national languages / Vernacular languages (封建民族语言): The languages of various nations formed during the feudal period; to be precise, the feudal national language is precisely one of the main characteristics that distinguish various nations in later times. The emergence of feudal national languages caused the classical *lingua franca* to essentially exit the historical stage. Examples include English, German, Amharic, Bengali, Thai, and so on.

The Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise (地主-官僚妥协): Refers to a compromise reached between the *barbarians* (蛮族) and the Han Chinese landlord class in Northern China. The ethnic minority invaders abandoned the prospect of expropriating the land ownership of Han landlords in order to realize their own nation's *feudalization* (封建化); instead, they allowed chieftains at all levels to transform into bureaucrats at all levels, thus bureaucratizing their own nation. The underclass commoners among the ethnic minorities rapidly degenerated into miserable civilians under the bureaucratic system, indistinguishable from Han civilians, while the ethnic minority rulers became autocratic monarchs. Han Chinese landlords retained their land and continued to participate in state politics as bureaucrats, just as in the past. This process made land ownership, and even land property rights, in Northern China extremely stable under the impact of the great migrations of peoples; the bureaucratic system was not destroyed by feudalization at all, laying the foundation for the formation of the *restoration-bureaucratic state* (复辟官僚国家) and serving as the primary cause for the failure of China's feudalization. A similar phenomenon might also have occurred during the process of Islamic conquests.

Co-optation through official ranks and stipends (官位荣禄收买): Refers to the covert weakening measures adopted by the government against the aristocratic great clans (门阀士族)—who were large-scale land owners—during the Sui and Tang dynasties, when China's *restoration-bureaucratic state* was newly established. The rulers conferred high positions within the bureaucratic system upon the aristocratic great clans, luring them into defending the authority of the bureaucratic system and concentrating their residence in Chang'an and Luoyang, thereby preventing them from becoming land-holding lords. The *restoration-bureaucratic state* effectively undermined

the foundation upon which the aristocratic great clans were formed: namely, their control over the *means of production* (生产资料) and production itself, as well as their ability to bear military obligations based on land. This ostensible valuing, combined with overt and covert suppression, led to the decline and fall of the aristocratic great clans within three centuries; since then, China's landlord class has been unable to voice any noteworthy opinions in politics.

Bureaucratized landlords (官僚化地主): By this point, readers should be highly familiar with the nature of the group known as the *Xiangshen* (local scholar-elites 乡绅) in late imperial China. I list these concepts to emphasize that "the opposition between bureaucrats and landlords" and "the inextricable link between bureaucrats and landlords" were phenomena existing simultaneously within the *restoration-bureaucratic state*. The opposition refers to the bureaucratic system preventing landlords from seizing power: the normal evolutionary direction of landlords is to develop into feudal lords conducting political rule, but the bureaucratic system prevented this and incorporated the landlords into itself. This is an opposition in the evolutionary path, rather than a clear-cut dichotomy in the resultant outcome. The social status and rights of bureaucratized landlords derived primarily from the bureaucratic system, not from their control over the means of production. Their secondary economic identity was as landlords, while their primary political identity was as bureaucrats.

Resident feudal lords (在地领主): Feudal lords who reside on the land they own and participate in the production and management of the manor. Resident feudal lords possess relatively strong enthusiasm and capability for improving operational methods and raising agricultural levels.

The Han System (汉制): Refers to the political system—supported by China's unique classical bureaucratic system—formed through the *Genghua* (Reform) Movement during the reign of the seventh emperor, Emperor Wu of Han, Liu Che. Formed at the climax of the Han-Xiongnu Wars, the Han System carried a highly pronounced wartime flavor, exhibiting extreme mobilization capacity and predatory nature. The Han System's investments in military and technological fields were highly successful; within two centuries, it proved itself to be a terrifying instrument of war and a paragon of government intervention driving technological progress and popularization. Unlike typical classical bureaucratic systems, the classical bureaucratic system under the Han System endowed the entire bureaucratic apparatus with a unified ideology and a self-metabolizing system of official selection, along with standards for evaluation, promotion, and demotion. This led to the emergence of a *scholar-official stratum* (士大夫阶层) that shared common values, benefited through the bureaucratic system, and was highly bound to it. These characteristics of the Han System later became crucial reasons for the failure of China's feudalization and the reconstruction of the *restoration-bureaucratic state*. The political systems of the Wei and Jin dynasties before the end of classical China can also be viewed as an evolution of the Han System during the early stage of feudalization.

The Tang System (唐制): Namely, the political system implemented during the Tang Dynasty; it serves as a milestone after the emergence of the *restoration-bureaucratic state*. Although the Tang System reserved political positions for the then-still-powerful aristocratic great clans and retained a massive number of feudalization characteristics, its ultimate goal was always to completely

obliterate the threat feudalization posed to the bureaucratic state—and it indeed possessed the capability to achieve this goal. Because the Tang System was able to maintain strong military capabilities in the short term and, unexpectedly, could be utilized in the manner of the classical era and the period preceding it, it caused immense destruction to China's periphery.

The Song System (宋制): Namely, the political system implemented during the Song Dynasty; it is the mark of complete maturity for the *restoration-bureaucratic state*. The Song System utterly eliminated the threat posed by the feudal landlord class to the *restoration-bureaucratic system*; it no longer left any place for the aristocratic stratum within China's political structure, indiscriminately placing the entire society under the rule of the *restoration-bureaucratic state*. However, the Song System still possessed the flexibility to release feudal elements in moments of critical peril to preserve itself. The Song System belongs to a highly specialized political system evolved from the processes of Chinese society; it is almost impossible for other nations to emulate it, and therefore it poses less of a threat externally.

Late Imperial China (中华帝国晚期): In the Chinese context, this precisely refers to the Ming and Qing dynasties.

Our timeline (本位面): Refers to the real world in which we currently live.

Chaotic Era (乱纪元): Refers to historical periods characterized by the frequent occurrence of unpredictable, large-scale catastrophic events.

Political efficiency (政治效率): Refers to the capability and efficiency of a political system (e.g., a state, government, political party, etc.) in achieving its established goals or satisfying social needs. It measures the political system's ability to achieve maximum results with minimal resource input.

Social being / Social existence (社会存在): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of the material living conditions of society that people are situated in during a certain historical period, particularly their *mode of production* (生产方式), *relations of production* (生产关系), and the social structure determined by these relations.

Social consciousness (社会意识): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of various ideologies, viewpoints, emotions, psychology, and the various forms expressing these contents that arise on the basis of a certain *social being*. Sometimes I also refer to it as *social concepts* (社会观念).

Social foundation (社会基础): When I use this term, it refers to the sum total of the various elements and conditions necessary to constitute the normal operation and stable existence of a society.

Minzhi / The people's intellectual and emotional capacity (民智): Knowledge at the rational level, as well as the ability to acquire, understand, and master knowledge; coupled with emotions at the perceptual level, as well as the ability to generate, perceive, and express emotions.

Minli / The people's physical capacity and labor (民力): Primarily refers to primary labor power represented by physical labor. However, in actual usage, it goes beyond this; for example, Chinese rulers driving the common people into war also belongs to a part of extracting "Minli," even though war obviously does not constitute productive labor.

Productive forces (生产力): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the capability of a specific society to transform nature and acquire material resources during the production process.

Relations of production (生产关系): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the mutual relations formed by people during the production process; it is the position people occupy and the form of their mutual connections in the process of producing, distributing, exchanging, and consuming material resources.

Economic base (经济基础): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of the dominant *relations of production* in a certain society, which constitutes the foundation of the social formation.

Superstructure (上层建筑): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of various political, legal, ideological, and cultural institutions established upon a certain *economic base* and serving to maintain that *economic base*.

Labor productivity (劳动生产率): An important indicator for measuring economic efficiency, reflecting the quantity of output generated per unit of labor input. Simply put, it measures how much value is created or how many products are produced by a worker within a unit of time.

Infrastructural power (基础性权力): In accordance with the views of Michael Mann, this refers to the capacity of the state to penetrate and coordinate the various spheres of society through social infrastructure (such as laws, administrative agencies, education systems, transportation networks, communication systems, etc.). Infrastructural power emphasizes institutionalized, cooperative, and long-term impact. In Imperial China, those who exercised infrastructural power were primarily the general administrative bureaucrats mentioned in Chapter 9, Section 7. Because exercising infrastructural power makes it easy for bureaucrats to transform into the ruling class by appropriating the means of production, for the supreme ruler, it is best if these general administrative bureaucrats are rotating officials (*Liuguan* / 流官).

Despotic power (专制性权力): In accordance with the views of Michael Mann, this refers to the capacity of state rulers to arbitrarily intervene in social life without being constrained by institutional checks. Despotic power emphasizes arbitrariness, repressiveness, and short-term impact. In Imperial China, those who exercised despotic power were primarily the highly specialized bureaucrats mentioned in Chapter 9, Section 7, whose purpose was to expand and safeguard the monarch's interests. They were highly dependent on the supreme ruler and could not easily transform into the ruling class; for the supreme ruler, it is best if these servile retainers (奴才) possess a hereditary nature (世袭性).

Middle Ages and *Chūsei* (中世纪和中世): When I use the concepts of the "*Middle Ages*" spoken of by Europeans, the "*Chūsei*" spoken of by the Japanese, and "*feudal society*" (封建社会), I make no distinction among them; they refer to the exact same thing. By European standards, it roughly refers to the timeframe defined by the social formation between 500 CE and 1500 CE. Sometimes this concept is also expressed as the "*medieval period*" (中古).

Early Middle Ages or Early Feudal Period (中世纪早期或封建早期): Namely, the timeframe defined by the social formation of Western Europe between 500 CE and 1000 CE.

High Middle Ages or High Feudal Period (中世纪盛期或封建盛期): Namely, the timeframe defined by the social formation of Western Europe between 1000 CE and 1300 CE. The High Middle Ages is a historical period of comprehensive social resurgence; during this stage, major social indicators such as population and economic scale surpassed the levels of the *classical period* (古典时期).

Late Middle Ages or Late Feudal Period (中世纪晚期或封建晚期): Namely, the timeframe defined by the social formation of Western Europe between 1300 CE and 1500 CE.

The Early modern period (近世/近代): Namely, the "early modern era." The historical period from the collapse of feudal society to the formation of modern society.

Early modern society (近世社会): A social formation transitioning from a feudal society to a capitalist society (modern society). Its characteristics include the formation of nation-states, absolutist rule, the frequent launching of foreign wars with persistently high military expenditures, a surge in economic circulation, intellectual liberation and the Scientific Revolution, the disintegration of the hierarchical system (等级制度), the rise of the civic class (市民阶层), and so on. Because Western scholars have long studied their own early modern history thousands of times over, it is impossible for me to add anything new. The only point I wish to emphasize is that early modern society possesses characteristics of *class transition* (阶级过渡) similar to the classical period: capital replaces land as the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素), and the bourgeoisie is in the process of replacing the *feudal landlord class* (封建地主阶级) to become the ruling class of the state. The relative balance of power among various social classes and the inconsistency of their demands became the social foundation upon which the absolute monarchy of the early modern state could be established and maintained for a certain period. Although it will inevitably cause controversy, I insist on classifying Edo-period Japan as an early modern state. Only a very small number of countries in the world have experienced early modern society, and having experienced early modern society can almost be viewed as a prerequisite for becoming a developed country today (excluding pocket states; simultaneously, for former colonies that inherited the religious, cultural, and linguistic characteristics of their metropolises, their historical processes prior to independence are viewed as identical to those of their metropolises, because these former colonies essentially replicated the social structures of the metropolises).

Absolute monarchy (绝对君主制): Specifically refers to the political system wherein, under the condition of a class transition within the ruling class of an early modern society, the monarch is constrained neither by the feudal system nor by the state apparatus of the bourgeoisie, resulting in a surge of the monarch's *despotic power* (专制性权力). When I use this term, I strictly confine it to early modern monarchical states, represented by Bourbon France. Any political system where the society has not reached the early modern stage, yet the monarch possesses immense *despotic power*, cannot be viewed as an absolute monarchy—whether it be the Ottoman Empire, the Ming and Qing empires, the Inca Empire, or modern-day Brunei and Saudi Arabia.

Absolutist state (绝对主义国家): No different from the universally accepted definition in academia.

Early modern state (近世国家): States established on the foundation of early modern society. Monarchical early modern states will generally develop characteristics of an absolute monarchy at a certain stage. A few early modern states appear to have become republics or figurehead monarchies (i.e., constitutional monarchies) very early on; however, one should note that the indigenous territories of these states are very small, and practically no relatively independent developmental process existed. They originally ought to have been a part of the political balance within a larger early modern regime—namely, the regions with the most developed commercial and industrial economies—but ultimately became independent due to Europe's complex political shifts. The Netherlands is precisely such a case.

Capitalism (资本主义): I personally have never been abroad and have never seen it, and the social stage in which this economic system emerged is simply too distant from China; therefore, I cannot make any evaluation. Just following the universally recognized standards in academia will suffice.

Capitalist society (资本主义社会): Ditto. It is difficult for me to comprehend personally; it should be a society that implements a capitalist economic system where the bourgeoisie holds the ruling position. What I want to say is that capitalist societies, in the vast majority of regions where they operate relatively well, are built upon the foundation of the local area having experienced an early modern society, or else they were colonies established after the Age of Discovery. Obviously, it is absolutely not the case that a society at just any random developmental stage can transform into a capitalist society by forcibly transplanting a capitalist economic system. Currently, I can only observe extremely rare exceptions like the Republic of Korea. Considering the connection between the historical processes of China and the Korean Peninsula, I believe South Korea's success holds immense value for China.

Capitalist state (资本主义国家): Ditto. It is difficult for me to comprehend personally. A state established upon a capitalist society. As far as I know, the degree of democracy in capitalist states is the best in history, which perhaps precisely reflects the significance of the social restructuring that has occurred since the High Middle Ages. However, whether modern society and capitalist society can truly be equated seems to have no conclusive verdict.

Modern society and Modern state (现代社会和现代国家): Difficult to evaluate; it is hard for me to know exactly what these two concepts look like. At present, it seems capitalist society is synonymous with modern society, and a modern state is a capitalist state.

Modernity (现代性): I basically agree that modernity is a form of social development and culture opposed to traditional society, with its core lying in the belief in rationality, science, progress, and universality. It originated from the Enlightenment in Europe and gradually expanded globally in the 19th and 20th centuries; however, outside of developed nations, the acceptance of modernity by societies in other places is extremely limited.

Postmodernity (后现代性): Allegedly, postmodernity is a reflection upon and critique of modernity, arguing that the rationality, science, progress, and universality pursued by modernity are all illusory; it emphasizes plurality, difference, relativity, and deconstruction. However, since our society is still an unimaginably long way from the modern era, I am simply unable to accurately understand what developed countries consider to be postmodernity.

Definition of the various parts of Europe (欧洲各个部分的界定): As far as I know, there has never been a unified standard for dividing Western Europe, Northern Europe, Eastern Europe, Southern Europe, and Central Europe; this is even more difficult for a Chinese person like myself who has never been abroad. When I speak of "Western Europe" during the early stage of *feudalization* (封建化), I generally refer to the Europe of the Western Roman Empire, the core of which is England, France, Northern Italy, the Low Countries, and certain regions of western Germany. But why do I sometimes adopt the term "the western part of Europe"? The reason is that history is inherently dynamically changing. A simplest example is that the concept of Germany expanded drastically eastward during the High Middle Ages. If it is quite reasonable to say "Germany is a Western European country" in the 10th century CE, the Holy Roman Empire of 1300 CE looks, by all accounts, more like a Central European state. Therefore, when I speak of Western Europe or the western part of Europe, I actually intend to refer to the core region of feudal Europe. This concept indeed expanded over time, while Eastern Europe and Northern Europe are situated in the peripheral regions defined by their corresponding directional terms.

East Asia (东亚): The scope covered by the territories of the five present-day countries: China, North Korea, South Korea, Vietnam, and Japan. Because Xinjiang and Tibet belong to China, I also consider them to be in the East Asian region. However, when referring to Xinjiang, I view it as belonging to "Inner Asia" (亚洲内陆), and when referring to Tibet, I will simply say it belongs to the main body of the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau.

Handi / China Proper (汉地): Namely, the lands where the Han ethnic group constitutes the dominant majority. It basically corresponds to the scope defined by the 18 provinces during the Qing Dynasty, including Zhili, but excluding the present-day Northeast China region where the Han currently constitute the vast majority. When describing earlier time periods, regions like Yunnan and Guizhou might not be counted within *Handi*; however, readers will understand upon a moment's thought, and it does not affect comprehension.

Zhongyuan / The Central Plains (中原): A Chinese cultural-geographical concept, centered on Henan Province and radiating toward surrounding vast regions such as Guanzhong, Jiangnan, Huaisi, and Heshuo, viewed as the cradle of the Chinese nation and the center of civilization.

Northeast Asia (东北亚): The scope covered by Japan, North Korea, South Korea, Northeast China, and the Russian Far East, which should be completely consistent with the universally recognized Northeast Asia.

Korea (朝鲜): When I mention Korea or Koreans, I basically refer to the entire peninsula or the inhabitants of the entire peninsula. If I am referring to the North Korean regime (北朝鲜政权), it should be very easy to judge based on the context.

Eurasian Steppe (欧亚大草原): No different from the definition used in academia.

Southeast Asia (东南亚): No different from the general classification. However, sometimes when I mention Southeast Asia, I might be referring to Southeast Asia excluding the parts east of the Wallace Line (华莱士线) and the entire Philippines.

South Asia (南亚): When I speak of South Asia, it refers to the scope covered by the territories of the seven countries: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives, and does not include Afghanistan.

Central Asia (中亚): When I speak of Central Asia, it refers to the six countries: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, and Afghanistan. I count Afghanistan as Central Asia, but I do not count Xinjiang as Central Asia.

The Middle East (中东): When I speak of the Middle East, it refers to the region bounded by the Mediterranean Sea, the Black Sea, the Greater Caucasus Mountains, the Caspian Sea, and the Indian Ocean, and enclosed within Turkey, Cyprus, Egypt, and Iran—naturally including the territories of these four countries as well.

The Near East (近东): When I use the concept of the Near East, it basically refers to the Middle East prior to the Islamic conquests, but the specific regions it includes are smaller: it excludes the central and southern parts of the Arabian Peninsula that do not border the Red Sea, as well as the Iranian Plateau with the exception of its southwestern part (the southwestern part of Iran is included in the Near East because of the presence of the Elamite civilization / 埃兰文明).

中文原文:

30，关于概念使用和定义的问题

在这个十几万字大章的最后，因为本人不可避免地会引入一些自己提出的概念，一些用词也不一定非常准确，所以在这里给出我在使用历史名词时采用的定义标准，供读者参考和批评。

阶级与阶层：阶级和阶层虽然在用法上已经被长期混淆，但是我认为仍然应该进行最起码的区分努力。我不赞成把国家政府或者官僚体制视为一个阶级，因为在我看来“阶级”这个词应该表明其描述对象与某种特定的生产方式相关联，也就是说当一类人被划为一个阶级的时候，这个集合的特征是其“元素”普遍采用某种特定的生产方式直接创造生产力。正是因为阶级能够以各种方式参与劳动生产，他们才能够从技术，文化，艺术和生产关系等各个角度对人类文明产生影响。这其实反映了马克思主义的一贯观点，历史发展是由各个阶级的运动决定的。我认为马恩原有理论的完成度而言，我们没有必要否认它，而是应该尽可能的去伪存真，使之能够自治且普适。

与阶级不同，国家政府或者官僚体制是脱产的，你确实可以说他在生产关系中具有某种位置，甚至承担了重要的社会功能，但是他的确不和某种特定的生产方式挂钩。这样我们就把官僚体制置于阶级叙事中的一个特殊位置，这种分辨是非常有利的。同样的，你可以看到知识分子这个集合的元素也不一定采用一种共同的生产方式，所以我们也应该将其称为知识分子阶层，而不是阶级。阶级和阶层的一个显著的区别在于，阶级会随着时代发展产生和淘汰，这本质上是由生产方式的产生和淘汰所决定的。而承担特定社会功能的阶层可能会延续非常长的时间，这是因为社会功能不一定会随着阶级运动带来的社会形态变动而消失。苏美尔时期就有官僚阶层，就有知识分子阶层，今天这个世界也有，但是已经相隔五千年了。

我们还应该注意到的是，阶层的一个子集很有可能可以被划为阶级，因为阶层的整体未必具有一个一致的生产方式，但是对其一部分未必。例如说早期国家所存在的祭司，抛开其宗教和行政性质来说，祭司作为知识分子的一部将作为劳动力组成部分的知识投入到农业生产和工程建设当中，他们确实以特定的生产方式创造了生产力。因此把祭司叫做祭司阶级在很大程度上是被允许的，这也就是为什么人们通常谈到早期国家的统治阶级的时候，会把祭司算作其中一员。

最后，我认为应当把商人，特别是不负责生产商品，只负责流通环节的行商视为阶层而不是阶级。读者在正文中能看到，这种划分对我们解释“贸易型伪古典国家”和“晚期古典国

家”是有利的。而且我们也应当指出，虽然商人作为一个必要的社会功能不可或缺，但是其的确无法在一个大尺度系统中作为主要文化的创造者。只有像粟特城邦这种体量比较小，又因为处在主要贸易路线中，贸易通量极大时的社会，商业文化才能占到主导。

封建经济制度：指以个体小生产为主要生产模式，租佃制为主要经营方式，或者左一些地说为主要剥削方式（以上也即“封建生产方式”），自然经济色彩明显的经济制度。经济生产的基本单位一般是庄园。地租的形式随着封建经济的发展存在变化，总体来说是从劳役地租到实物地租再到货币地租。在各级封建地主通过取得政治统治地位成为封建领主之后，封建社会应该呈现出大土地所有权的特征，即土地经过各种形式的兼并集中程度达到高水平。农奴制在不同程度上存在，因具体环境的不同农民对于领主的依附程度强弱存在差异，但无论如何弱于早期的奴隶制。城市经济在中世纪早期属于庄园的附属物，但是在中世纪盛期已经取得了一定独立性，长途商业活动，货币经济和自治权发展明显。

主流剥削方式：在苏联式的史学中，阶级社会与该社会中占主流的剥削方式具有相当严格的对应关系。按照作者在学生时代所学的官方观点，奴隶制社会主流的剥削方式是通过强迫劳动强占剩余劳动；封建社会的主流剥削方式是通过地租掠夺剩余产品；资本主义社会的主流剥削方式是通过雇佣关系获得剩余价值。不过，我国社会科学领域定义的混乱远超外人想象，很多时候在中国人们也会把奴隶制下剥削获得的剩余劳动以及封建制下剥削获得的剩余产品直接归为剩余价值的一种，只是带有强烈的超经济属性。

我们必须承认，苏联是史学的观察并非一无是处，很显然占主流的剥削方式和阶级社会的类别一定是有强对应关系的。但是问题在于，历史事实表明人们很难认为一个可以归类为封建社会的社会所具有的主流剥削方式就一定是收取地租。在中世纪的早期和盛期，自然经济下的庄园制普遍拥有强迫劳动的制度。比如人们所熟知的中世纪欧洲封建农业生产中的

“3+3+1 模式”，即依附于领主土地的农奴需要无偿为领主劳动三天，他们需要带着自己的生产资料到领主的自营地上进行无偿的强迫劳动；农奴可以在自己所拥有的份地上劳作三天份，份地上所出产的粮食供养了农奴家庭；周日是安息日，是不允许进行农业劳作的。除了这种标准的剥削模式以外，农忙时节对农奴的劳役可能会加重。而且也不是所有的农民都是做三休三，拥有土地过少的半农奴甚至无法承担标准额度的劳役，只能通过给富裕农民或者领主做雇工换取粮食。而自由农则通常不需要承受强迫劳役，主要缴纳实物租或者货币租。

尽管人们通常把中世纪欧洲庄园制度的“劳役地租”视为用劳动力支付的一种特殊地租类型，但是这无法掩盖其强迫劳动的本质。只有到了中世纪晚期，劳役地租才大规模的向实物地租或货币地租转变，这也是庄园经济土崩瓦解的历史时期。一些重大历史事件，比如黑死病加速了这个过程。我们观察日本的历史将会得到同样的结论，在日本中世晚期庄园经济解体之后，租税成为全社会占有压倒性多数的剥削方式。丰臣秀吉所推行的“太阁检地”，通过石高制和年供确立了典型的租税剥削。只不过日本的商品经济仍不足以与西欧相较，其土地税收中实物税的占比更高。因此如果我们按照苏联式史学将阶级社会所对应的剥削方式在全社会占主流的时期视为其典型阶段，那么这个阶段其实并不会太长。以封建时期为例，在不到两个世纪，几代人的时间之后，随着城镇工商业的发展，雇佣劳动在社会经济中起到的作用愈发重要，封建社会开始出现动摇，历史进入了人们通常所谓的“早期近代”。

于是苏联式史学必然会产生一些感官上的矛盾。不管是在史学界还是普通公民眼中，事实上的封建体制最为成熟和典型的时期都是公元 1000 年到 1300 年间的中世纪盛期。这一时期基于（跨越世代的）土地分封和主从关系的契约网络在西欧大地上铺开，上级领主依赖于下级领主的军事服役，并承认其领有土地的权力。自然经济仍然占据主导定位，自然经济下应运而生的庄园制运转良好。领主住在庄园内，农奴通过强迫劳动在领主的自营地上劳作。社会结构被相当完美地理论化为三个等级，也就是所谓祈祷的人，战斗的人和劳作的人。封建宗教组织，也就是罗马天主教会的权势达到了顶峰，承担了大量的社会功能。这都是人们通常认为的封建制度（或者说中世纪）的典型人文景观。而到了中世纪晚期，常备军和雇佣军变得普遍，诸侯不一定亲自服役，封建军事制度发生了巨大变化。庄园制度瓦解，商品经济恢复，市民阶层壮大，宗教改革已在酝酿之中。哪怕中世纪晚期还是封建社会，但是人文景观已经变化很大了。可恰恰是到了中世纪晚期，如果按照苏联式史学将剥削方式与阶级社会对应的看法，典型的封建社会才出现。

这种苏联式史学解释上的不足之处，恰恰反映出文稿以首位生产要素定义阶级社会的意义。事实上，人们不难看出，哪怕从表象上看，早期国家或古典帝国的奴隶在种植园里挥汗如雨，和中世纪早期和盛期的农奴在领主的自营地上服劳役，似乎都是“强迫劳动”，但是毕竟有显著的区别，那就是封建社会的强迫劳动是基于土地依附关系的。奴隶不占有任何生产资料，甚至不存在任何私产，连自己的身体都难以掌控，他们本身就被视为主人可以随意处置（特别是买卖）的私产。奴隶的必要劳动和剩余劳动在时空上完全混淆，主人几乎占有奴隶的全

部产出，只拨出很小一部分生活资料来维持奴隶的生存。相比之下，农奴享有一定的法律人格，部分占有生产资料，特别是拥有份地的用益权。农奴不像牲畜一样可以随便买卖，可以被领主随意杀害，一般只能随土地一同易主。农奴所受的强迫劳动在时空上也是清晰割裂的，比如一周三天在自己份地上的劳动成果归属自己，另外三天在领主的土地上无偿劳动的成果归属领主。农奴和领主之间的义务也不完全是单向的，后者也需要为前者提供司法服务和军事保护。因此，我们可以看出，哪怕在中世纪早期和中世纪盛期地租还不是主流的剥削方式，但是土地已经在社会生产中占据了核心位置，成为了首位的生产要素，社会的“封建属性”是毋庸置疑的，这也是为什么会有“劳役地租”这种说法的原因。以首位生产要素定义阶级社会，历史分期就变得更加简单明了，而不至于使人混淆了。

正如文稿第十三章第五节所说，即使是同一个词汇，在不同的社会形态下，其内涵也并不相同。我们这里姑且基于马克思主义的解释来举例。在封建社会，地租，无论是中前期的劳役地租还是晚期的实物和货币地租，它几乎就是整个社会剥削形式的全部。领主对农奴的剥削不基于市场契约，而是依靠自己的政治特权和超经济的强制力。如果农奴不交租，领主可以动用司法和军队进行镇压。资本主义社会中，土地依然是重要的生产资料，地租也继续存在。但是标准的资本主义农业结构是“三元”的：土地所有者把土地租给农业资本家，农业资本家在雇佣农业工人在土地上劳作。这样地租就只是剩余价值的一部分，真正的剥削行为发生在农业资本家通过支付工资给雇佣工人完的过程中。农业资本家将总利润的一部分拿出来，作为使用土地的租金交给土地所有者。资本主义社会中地租没有超经济强制的特征，现在地主不能够动用私刑去逼迫租赁土地者交租，其行为必须基于经济契约，法律产权和市场规范。因此在中世纪结束之后的近代社会，哪怕收取地租在很长时间内仍然是主流的剥削方式，但是这并不妨碍封建社会向资本主义社会发生过渡，因为地租所具有的性质的确是在变动的。

苏联是史学还有一个问题，那就是它经常把庄园经济中存在的强迫劳动行为简单地称为一种“奴隶制残余”，这赋予其一种强烈的贬义色彩。然而，实情显然不会那么简单，且不论社会发展阶段之间的过渡本来就需要漫长时间，庄园经济的存在也有其正面意义。除了我们已经谈到过的农奴本身的地位和待遇比起奴隶的本质提升以外。在商品经济萎缩的自然经济状态下，庄园不仅是行政单位，也是农业生产的核心。领主如果仅向农民征收货币，货币很难花出去。如果只收实物，遇到灾年农民交不上来，领主全家就要陷入危机。在这种状态下，领主为了保持生存和军事供给，就需要亲手掌控一部分核心土地，也就是所谓的自营地。

在地领主通过强迫劳役组织生产具有一定正面意义，他们提供基础设施和生产资料，进行资源整合，管理生产，并且建立秩序，负责安保。在地领主和庄园管家直接参与并干预生产过程并从中获利，这也会激发他们对于农业改良的热情。统治者和被统治者在居住空间上接近，又共同关注生产劳动，这对于封建契约精神的形成是必要的。领主和农奴的地位虽然极不平等，但是仍然是一种在当时利于双方的契约关系，领主也需要承担管理，生产和保护庄园的义务。庄园内部的司法实践虽然维护封建等级，但是也使习惯法清晰起来，促进了基层社会的规则意识。总而言之，庄园经济虽然具有强迫劳动的剥削实质，但它毕竟适应了当时低下的生产力水平和混乱的社会现实，成功地将分散的人口组织起来，推动了农业技术的迭代，并确立了以契约和土地为核心的封建秩序。

等到中世纪晚期庄园经济解体，实物和货币地租成为主流的剥削方式之后。封建领主反而退出了农业生产管理，不再直接干预，因而也不如以前关心。作为统一生产单位的庄园消失了，现在只剩下纯粹的“收租辖区”。领主退出生产并且向不在地主和宫廷贵族转化预示着封建制度的盛极而衰。当领主退出组织生产，不再扮演军事、司法保护和生产资料提供者的角色是，他在农民眼中也就不再是一个“合法的保护者和管理者”，而越来越接近一个吸血鬼的角色。

苏联式史学通常具有这样一种倾向，那就是认为“典型的阶级社会是漫长而稳定的，之间的过渡期要短暂很多”。但是我们观察到的历史真相并非如此，（苏联式史学定义的）典型的阶级社会形态存在的时间并不长，几乎不会长于两个世纪，十代人的时间。甚至于即使把文稿所重新定义的阶级社会之间的过渡状态，也就是古典社会和近世社会，算作与三个阶级社会相并列的历史阶段。那么这些历史序列上的“标准社会形态”都不算漫长，它们之间的演化过程占据了大多数的历史岁月。这也再次加强了文稿的观点，即社会变革是长期的事业。

具体到中国，苏联式的历史宣传因为中国特殊的历史进程被加强了。一些历史表述相当激进，比如有人指出自公元前六世纪初鲁国“初税亩”开始，经过春秋战国时期各诸侯国的一系列改革运动，中国在古典帝国统一前期就已经是一个以土地租税为主流剥削方式的，封建经济占主体的国家，并且这种状态一直延续到了最后一个王朝清朝。但实际上，明智的人能看出这种叙事很有问题，因为中华帝国长期以来征收也人头税，这本质上是一种对劳动力征收的赋税。以汉朝这个古典帝国为例，官方所定的田赋从来都很低，但是人头税也就是口赋给人

民带来的负担极重。如果再考虑到汉朝政府要求百姓所必须承担的沉重的徭役，那么似乎缺少理由认为古典时期的中国地租已经超过强迫劳动成为主流的剥削方式。

我国历史上，剥削的重心从劳动力转移到土地的标志性事件应当是唐朝中后期所实行的“两税制”。很可能直到公元后的第一个千年的尾声，地租才成为中国社会剥削方式的主流。这个时间点很有意思，它当然比官方史学所认定的时间节点晚得多，但是又比欧洲和日本的封建社会从劳役地租转变成实物或货币地租要早很多。这在某种程度上反映了复辟官僚制度本身的成熟：它不再像隋朝和唐朝前期那样试图通过直接掌控并分配土地来对抗封建化，转而在承认封建经济形成的基础上维持自身。让地主阶级通过租税进行剥削方式，对于官僚制度本身是有利的。一旦中国的地主阶级不再像中世纪早期和盛期（以及早期中世纪中国）的在地领主一样建立庄园，提供农业生产资料，组织微观生产，用私兵保护农民，转而依靠朝廷的法律和衙门的强制力来催租。他们在生产力的发展上，就变成了没有组织贡献的寄生者，这反而进一步消除了其转变成为封建领主的可能。因此戏剧性的是，更早转入剥削地租的经济模式对中国而言不仅仅带来了政治上的灾难，它最终也迟滞了经济领域的发展。例如一个人尽皆知的事实是，对劳动力的制度性剥削在我国结束的非常晚，一直到清代中叶人头税才被彻底废除。而在那个时候，西方世界和日本早已进入近世社会了。中国的历史实际上从一个反面证明了庄园经济在中世纪早期和中世纪盛期的积极历史意义。人们在阅读中国历史的时候应当时刻记住的一条道理是：自然经济固然意味着商品经济的萎缩，但是同样也意味着官僚体制以汲取社会财富为目的的强迫流通的消亡。破坏自然经济的也不一定是商品经济的发展，还有可能是重建的官僚制度恢复了对社会财富的汲取。

中世日本的历史提供了一个同体系内（封建社会）的对比。我们之前也指出，在日本中世庄园公领制仍然运作的时期，日本庄园同样拥有一套具有本土特色的强迫劳动体系。然而值得注意的是，在日本庄园制度出现的整个历史时期，租税在剥削方式中的占比恐怕都要比欧洲的中世纪早期和中世纪盛期更大。这一方面是因为日本的封建化是在一个高度成熟的律令国家的废墟上孕育的，“租庸调”制度的惯性仍然存在。更为实际的原因则是，日本的封建制度不是入关蛮族通过征服而建立，而是武士团体从国家体制内部逐渐夺取政权。庄园公领制长期以来存在所有权和管理权的分离制，庄园的最高所有者是远在京都的宫廷贵族和大型寺社，因为不在庄园当地，自然需要依靠预所、下司、名主逐级把庄园的年贡送往京都。他们既然不可能跑到乡下去亲自监督农民劳作，也就不可能推崇欧洲中世纪早期和盛期在地领主

所收取的比较纯粹的劳役地租形式。这样一来，如果站在苏联式的史学上看，既然日本中世早期地租在剥削方式中占比同期欧洲更高，日本的封建化程度不就比较欧洲还高了吗？我们知道这显然是荒谬的。

庄园的下司和名主向武士转化不是一日之内就完成的。我认为日本的中世纪盛期应当定义在庄园已然解体的战国时期较为合适，战国大名几乎完全排除了律令国家公权力对生产的干预，实现了对土地的垄断和一元化支配。他们通过分国法，在自己领地内建立起了纯粹的封建契约与军事主从关系，规划治水、开垦金山，按照自己的需求组织领国内的生产，这些是封建制度在结构上达到全盛期的标志。而日本的中世晚期应当定义为织丰政权统治时期，封建领主开始脱离农业生产，大量底层武士变成拿固定俸禄的职业军人，剥削方式几乎全面转化为租税。这也再一次印证我们在第四章所谈到日本的时候所说的，欧洲的中世纪盛期同样是庄园制度的繁荣时期，而日本的中世盛期庄园制度已经瓦解了。日本的中世盛期和中世晚期显现出明显的滞后性和快速过渡性。根本原因在于日本的封建化虽然被律令官僚体制拖累了数个世纪，但是在漫长的时间的里，日本的农业生产水平和商品经济一直在发展。因此，当战国大名终于彻底砸碎官僚制度的枷锁时，日本的社会生产力已经冲破封建自然经济，商品经济的洪流和火器的引入，在几代人的时间又动摇了纯粹的封建结构。织丰政权顺势而为，以相当快的速度实现了向近世社会的过渡，也谱写了后人津津乐道的历史传奇。

庄园经济：与学界通用的定义无异。

封建政治制度：基于封建经济制度，在封建地主阶级取得政治统治权之后（自发）组织起的政治体制，以中世纪盛期的英、法、德地区为标准。最大的特征即层级明显的封建权力等级制度，存在一系列权利和义务，尤其是土地所有权和效忠关系具有世袭性。封建制度中存在以作为中下层统治阶级的军事贵族，翻译为骑士或者武士，其社会地位维持依赖于军事服役。

要注意的是，以上两个概念是以封建盛期作为标准，全世界各地的封建社会短则四五百年，长则上千年，显然存在一个发展的过程。例如早在北京篇的时候就已经提过，从财产继承制度的情况来看，整个封建时期就存在着由析产制向长子继承制的变化。因此，在坚持原则的前提下，实际判断还要结合具体情况分析。从较为宽松的角度来说，在土地作为首位生产要素的条件下，凡地主阶级作为统治阶级出现，并且在政治上完全取得主导权，能够贯彻其意志的社会皆属于封建社会。

准封建制度：具有一定程度的封建政治制度特征但是又没有达到封建政治制度标准的政治制度，以伊斯兰世界的伊克塔制度及其各种本地变形为例。

封建社会：实行封建经济制度和封建政治制度的社会。之所以只用提经济和政治两个方面，无非是因为这两个方面只要实现了，其余的因素都会自发地适应或者产生。

封建特征：封建社会所具有的经济、政治、军事、宗教和文化各个领域的特征。主要内容就是在封建经济制度和封建政治制度中。

封建时期：封建社会存在的历史时期。

封建主义：虽然“主义”这个词在中国非常偏向于意识形态和经济关系。但是当我提到封建主义的时候指的是封建社会所有特征的集合，包括经济制度，政治制度，军役制度，盛行宗教，社会观念等等。

封建化：这个概念被我用来形容封建社会演变的整个过程，它强调一种变化的趋势。

封建化程度：我们可以从两个层面去分析一个社会的封建化程度。在宏观层面上，封建化程度可以由土地作为首位生产要素，在生产关系、社会结构、政治组织与意识形态中的支配程度衡量，土地的支配程度越高则封建化程度越高。在微观层面上，封建化程度可以由对个人和家庭这样的社会基本单位而言，占有土地这种生产资料对获得社会地位和政治权利的决定性意义衡量，土地的决定性越大则封建化程度越高。

我们在提到“封建化”的时候，不使用传统中文史学中那样模糊的“分封制”概念，也不是单纯的用西欧历史上的“封君封臣制”进行简单概括。通俗来说，一个社会的经济生产越依赖土地，越围绕土地形成权力结构，越依赖地方土地控制实现政治组织，越依赖土地维系军事、身份、权利与等级，那么它的封建化程度就越高。相对应的商品经济、官僚机器、流通资本和过多的劳动力都会压制土地在社会中的决定性地位，意味着封建化程度的下降。

这里经常出现的一个例子就是日本战国时代的大名，因为日本在实现封建化的过程中仍然在形式上保留了律令制官位，因此土地的支配作用得以鲜明地显现了出来。人们经常说，为什么日本在战国后期已经是毋庸置疑的封建社会了呢？因为在那个年代，一个有50万石领地的大名在朝廷领到的官位几乎一定比5万石的大名高。木下藤吉郎出身贫寒，但是平定天下后却能获得关白之职和“丰臣朝臣”之氏姓。松平家原本也是名声不显的地方土豪，但是德

川家康受封征夷大将军之后，也没有人敢公开质疑他“源氏长者”的身份。正是因为朝廷官位已经成为了大名们基于土地占有的实力的点缀，我们才可以说日本武士最终完成了封建化的伟业。

那么如何区分封建化的“退潮”和封建社会向资本主义社会的自然演化呢？关键在于，当土地的重要性在公共领域和私人领域开始下降时，接替土地地位，开始承担土地原有功能的是不是资本。例如说，如果比较 17 世纪的荷兰和 14 世纪的北印度，那么极可能在后者土地要更具有决定性。但是我们却不能说“17 世纪的荷兰的封建化程度要低于 14 世纪的北印度”，这是因为 17 世纪的荷兰已经离开了封建社会，按照其正常历史发展向资本主义社会运动了。相反，如果土地的地位下降，但是在决定社会分配上愈发重要的是初级劳动力或者官僚权力，那么这就是封建化在没有完成的时刻就发生了退潮。封建化的完成意味着土地把自己原先的“权柄”交给资本，而不能是什么别的。

因此文中在讨论伊斯兰教历史的时候，强调的是伊斯兰教能够有效征服前封建的地区。例如大河两岸的灌溉地区，城市商业网络发达的地区，古典社会仍然没有消失的地区，早期国家或者前国家社会，以及封建化非常微弱的地区。这些地方土地尚未彻底主导社会结构，缺少稳固的封建共同体，扎根地方的武装，与社会深度绑定的封建宗教。对于已经完成封建进程的国家，虽然土地已经不再像中世纪那样主导社会结构，但是封建社会所形成的组织和文化遗产留了下来，并且将很快转化成生产力、国家能力特别是军事实力，这也不是伊斯兰征服者能够轻易撼动的。

一个地区的社会所封建化速度、能达到的最大封建化程度一定是受到其自然地理条件制约的，这是任何人都无可奈何的事情。在人类对于自然的改造能力尚且不足的年代，地理环境确实会对人类社会产生极大的，有时甚至是决定性的作用。

最后，我想说明我们为什么在确定封建化程度的时候，在宏观层面外还要考虑微观层面呢？在这里我有两点考量。

首先是从历史研究本身的特征出发，绝大多数史料都会受到作者本人经历的强烈影响，因此宏观态势是比较难把控的，而微观层面上的证据更为直接。甚至于从社会生活史研究出发，历史资料不一定只能从传统史料中找，文学作品、契约文书等其他文献资料乃至非文献资

料的文物都能提供大量信息，就如同文稿中通过《红楼梦》来揭示中华帝国晚期社会图景一样。

其次，微观层面的限制能够有效排除稀缺性关系对宏观层面判断的影响。以我们在文稿中谈到的乌尔第三王朝为例，在封建化远未开始之时，的确有可能存在一种明显的“人多地少”的社会，使得土地的重要性异常上升，甚至能够盖过初级劳动力。然而我们指出，稀缺性所带来的社会分配变化往往是增强了国家权力在分配中的主导作用，而不是增强了相对稀缺的生产要素本身在分配中的主导作用。这是因为在自然状况下稀缺性是难以瞬间产生的，在“人多地少”的最终状态形成的过程中，政府能够通过其国家力量增强了对土地的垄断。因此，在乌尔第三王朝这个人地型伪古典国家，虽然看起来土地在社会结构中占据了非常重要的地位，但是就其国民来说，他所能拥有的社会地位和政治权利首先是由乌尔官僚体系中的位置决定的。这也说明乌尔第三王朝远远不能算作一个真正的古典国家。只有各生产要素数量相对均衡，能够在当前技术水平下充分转化为生产力时，才能够最清晰地判断其中哪一个生产要素取得了首要地位。

对于封建化的定义有可能推广到其他阶段的阶级社会，但是因为封建时期是本文讨论的重点，对早期国家和资本主义社会的研究处于次要位置，因此在这里不做延伸。

封建地主阶级：封建经济制度中的统治阶级，是生产资料的控制者和社会生产的主导者。但是我在使用封建地主阶级这个概念时仅仅指的是其在政治上未能取得统治权的情况，例如在复辟官僚时期的中国。

十分有趣的是，在马克思主义史学和政治经济学的经典定义中，封建地主阶级这一概念的表述相当精确：在封建社会（或半殖民地半封建社会）中，占有土地，并以此为基础，通过地租、高利贷或超经济强制（人身依附关系）剥削农民（佃农）的那个统治阶级。这里所说的地租就包括了中世纪庄园经济下的劳役地租。总而言之，封建地主阶级就是基于对土地的占有和使用来主导社会生产的，在土地居首位生产要素之位时所形成的生产关系中的统治阶级。

封建领主：在政治上取得统治权的封建地主阶级，我主要将这个概念用在封建的欧洲和日本。

封建时期的土地所有权：无论如何，即使是在西欧和日本那样典型的封建社会，封建领主所拥有的“土地所有权”都绝不可能与现在意义上的土地所有权完全相同，前现代社会的法律概念也不可能与现代社会一样清楚和完善。毕竟封建社会和现代社会之间还隔了近世这样一

个完整的历史阶段，如今人类社会的复杂程度就完全不是之前任何一个历史时期能够想象的。归根到底，中世纪封建领主对于土地的所有权还是一种附带义务的用益权（Usufruct）。如果将其理解成为绝对的支配权，那就连层层分封这种政治现象都难以解释了。当我们说“封建领主取得土地所有权”这件事的时候，其实指的还是封建领主具有对自己土地有非常全面的管理和处分的权力，比如收取地租，征收劳役，行使司法权，行政管理，军事指挥，赠予土地，继承土地和分封下级领主等。而且尤其重要的是，这种权力得到了全社会的普遍认可，成文法或习惯法的保护，绝不是可以被轻易剥夺的。这样我们就足以把实际治理自己世袭领地，并且可以分封下级领主的欧洲和日本的封建领主与仅仅获得土地收益权或者征税权作为军事服役报酬的伊斯兰世界军事贵族相区分。

首位生产要素：即所有生产要素中具有首要地位的一个，具体概念在第六章第四节。

正文中提到了首位生产要素的三个判定维度，它们构成了成为首位生产要素的充分条件。不过在这里我还想特别强调一点，某一生产要素（或同时也是生产资料）想要获得首要地位，那么它至少应该具有某种不可复制性。

我们思考这样一个有意思的问题。在农业时代，人们在土地里劳作需要农具和牲畜。在资本主义时代，证券交易所的交易员需要计算机和软件。人类自从有劳动生产以来，就离不开生产工具的帮助，生产工具毋庸置疑属于生产资料的范畴。但是为什么生产工具本身难以成为首位生产要素呢？或者我们更进一步的说，工具为什么通常不能决定社会组织结构？回答是：工具一般具有高度可复制性，它往往是可以扩散的。这就造成了一个结果，那就是拥有社会地位和权力的人很容易获得大量的生产工具，而并非拥有大量生产工具的人能够轻易获得社会地位和权力。这和土地这样不可替代，不可再生的生产资料有巨大的差别：农具可以批量制作，坏了还可以再打造，但是土地不行。假如本身不占有土地，那么一个人即使有再多的农具和耕牛都是徒劳。因此，工具性生产资料本身通常难以形成支配他人的社会关系，它更多只是既有社会关系得以实现和扩大的媒介。

本文内容中所涉及的一个特例是大河两岸干旱地区的大型灌溉系统。它作为一种基础设施性质的，具有明确空间属性的公共生产资料，与农具和计算机这样可以搬回家的生产工具截然不同。大型灌溉系统具有明显的不可复制性和空间属性，并且赋予土地以生产价值，所以它开始具有土地的性质，能够成为塑造社会关系的强大力量。所以文中会说，灌溉系统的重要

性已经能够明显抑制土地在所有生产要素中的首要地位，这就是为什么大河两岸的灌溉农业能够对封建化产生明显阻碍。

这就是我为什么在“对未来的思考”这一独立于文稿的短篇中提到，AI的兴起有可能使得“民智”成为首位生产要素，而不是人工智能本身成为首位生产要素。因为照目前看来，AI仍然只是工具，其复制和自由获取不存在根本阻碍。它和以往的许多生产工具一样，都缺少配置其他生产资料的能力。AI服务器不能决定知识属于谁，只能提高获取知识的效率。它依然只是放大生产关系，而不是决定生产关系，因此也就无法成为决定社会组织方式的核心。与之相反，AI倒是有可能作为一种新时代的生产工具，将人类的“不可替代的创造性智能”托举到首位生产要素的位置。

进而我们也可以看到资本主义的特殊性。回想一下迄今为止依次出现的首位生产要素：初级劳动力当然是不能复制的，或者戏谑一点地说，劳动力的增加本身就是劳动力自己创造的（通过繁殖行为）；土地是物质的，具有明确空间属性的，具有非常明确的不可复制性。相比之下，资本就特殊很多了。诚如马克思所言，资本是一种社会关系。就其表象的物理形态来说，资本不但是可复制的，还可能非常过剩。例如纸币本身可以被无限印刷，已有的生产线复制多少条在技术上也不是问题。这种特征也是资本主义辉煌成就的基石之一，即打破了土地的物理局限，创造了前所未有的物质财富。而资本的不可复制性则集中体现在社会关系上形成的“排他性壁垒”，包括法律垄断（如专利和知识产权），经济垄断（如资本门槛），市场垄断（如品牌、网络效应、数据霸权）乃至最终的权力集中。于是这样我们就看到了资本的不可复制性的两个重要的特点：

第一，资本的不可复制性不像土地的不可复制性那样属于生产资料的固有特点，而是依赖于制度与设施实体及社会意识形态构成的上层建筑。这就导致国家权力本身有能力破坏其不可复制性。因此，人们可以在世界各地看到对于这一现象的不同表述：在苏联这样的马列主义国家，人们说“资产阶级具有软弱性”；在美国这样的资本主义心脏，马斯克说“是权力而非资本在剥削”。这些话虽然不能尽信，但是他们的确反映了资本主义的一个鲜明的特点，那就是资本是嵌入在社会组织和权力结构中的，其独立性远不如土地。因此国家机器有能力通过专制性权力侵犯资本的不可复制性，从而在压制资本在生产中的主导地位。因此人们之所以感觉到在资本主义社会，国家权力的扩张更难受到统治阶级的制衡，并不完全只是社会

复杂性大大增加进而国家机构随之膨胀的结果。这也是我在文稿中提醒即使是发达国家，也绝不应该自以为民主制度已经实行很久就漠视复辟官僚制度的威胁的原因。

第二，那些保证资本具有不可复制性的上层建筑有相当一部分都是完整封建化过程结出的成果。例如，对于专利和知识产权的认可和保护，乃至对于国家权力进行限制和制衡的社会观念，从实践上看，那些没有经历完整封建社会的国家很难获得。这样就形成了一个很奇特的局面，许多能够确保资本作为稳固的首位生产要素（进而维持资本主义社会）的因素，本身就是封建社会中长出来的。这显示出资本和土地决定性的不同，土地的固有属性并不因社会组织 and 权力结构而改变。所以我们能看到，像西欧这样经历了古典社会的地区能够封建化，像中欧、北欧这样从来没有经历过古典社会的地区也能封建化，因为土地的性质根本不在乎社会此前有没有经历过古典社会。但是资本在乎社会此前有没有此前经历过封建社会，因为正是封建社会的重要遗产，使得资本能够坐稳首位生产要素的宝座，令社会围绕资本进行组织，建立起稳固的资本主义社会。这样就实际上形成了一个文明的“大过滤器”，再次印证了本文的观点，即封建时期在人类文明中占有不可动摇的中心地位。

当然，正如本文一直强调的，作者本人从来没有见过真正的资本主义社会，因此对于资本主义的许多观点，都只能立足于推测，对资本主义的认识自然难以和发达国家的公民相提并论，我也就不再深入研究了。

稀缺性关系：指的是各生产要素基于供求关系在数量上的多寡对比，不足的生产要素地位增加，有余的生产要素地位下降。稀缺性关系不直接作用于生产力，但是会对生产方式产生影响。在人类历史中表现最普遍的稀缺性关系是人地关系，即劳动力和土地的相对多寡。当各生产要素在现有技术水平下均可充分转化为生产力时，可以认为各生产要素处于相对平衡状态，没有谁是明显富余的，也没有谁是明显短缺的。

商品经济和自然经济：跟学界使用的定义没有区别。

人们大概会有这样一个问题，自然经济兴起究竟是封建化的原因呢，还是封建化的结果呢？我的观点是，历史中的很多重大现象本来也无法仅仅视为单向的因果关系，而是多个变量可能彼此强化，最终进入新的均衡状态。自然经济在一段时间内占据优势的根源在于，生产力发展到了这样一个阶段，自给自足的生产在综合收益（包括风险）上超过了存在成本的商品流通。这并非不可思议，从古典时期到封建时期，生产力的增长是有限的。人类依然处于农

业社会，社会分工的复杂程度没有出现本质的变化，那么一个大型庄园完成绝大多数生产需求的确是可能的。自然经济能够占据优势，不是因为生产力低下，而是在生产力发展的过程中，生产体系还简单到允许自然经济成为优势。在工业革命之后，即使生产力迅速发展，也不可能回到那种自给自足的经济模式了，因为现代生产体系已经复杂到没有任何地方能够独立完成全部生产。

因此，自然经济的兴起是封建化的重要推动因素，特别是这个过程增强了土地在各个生产要素中的地位。但是反过来，封建化过程也在进一步加强自然经济。当地主阶级考虑到在其所处生产力条件下，自然经济比起依赖交换网络的商品经济在经济上更具效率，他们当然会作出回应。如果大量生产者开始减少市场参与，那么帝国的税收会下降，城市会衰退，商人减少，货币流通萎缩，道路维护变差，进而流通成本进一步提高，然后更多的生产者退出市场。自然经济和封建化过程开始相互促进。

当然仍然需要提醒读者的是，“自然经济兴起”这个说法肯定不如“自然经济变得最具经济效益”这个说法合理。我们之前提到过，很多所谓的“封建化的特征”本质上是和之前的“古典时代的特征”对比之下得到的。对于罗马、北印度和中国境内经历了古典帝国鼎盛时期的地区来说，他们有过商品经济高度繁荣的时期，那个时候专业化生产的收益远远大于运输成本。因此当生产力发展到一定阶段，在这些地方能够观察到自然经济开始普遍取代商品经济成为主要的经济模式。而对于那些没有经历过古典时代便开始封建化的地区而言，“自然经济进一步发展”就显得非常奇怪了。对于北欧和东欧的很多地方，在明显封建化之前很难说存在什么发达的商品经济能够消亡。这些地区的封建化过程中不但自然经济在发展，商品经济大概率也在发展，原因无非是那里之前太落后了。

甚至于我们从经济学上考虑，在封建化初期，自然经济最开始的发展不一定要求土地的自给生产相对于流通交换一定在效率上有优势，很可能前者只要在效率上接近后者就足够了。原因在于，人们在进行经济决策的时候从来都不是只考虑回报的期望，而是会认真地考虑风险效率，特别是这种风险能不能在自己手中得到一定控制。我们举一个很经典的问题，假设现在有 A、B、C、D 四种投资方式，经过长期的统计来看这四种投资方式的期望回报有明显的大小关系。但是，精明的理财专家也不一定会把所有资金都投入到回报期望最高的那种投资方式中，因为高的回报期望也可能带来惊人的风险。最后，人们大概率会选择一种复合式的投资。如果我们在街上进行随机采访，一个选项是有 50% 的概率获得一亿元，50% 的概率

失去 500 万元，另一个选项是 100% 的概率获得 1000 万元。那么前者的回报期望当然还是高于后者，但是很可能大部分人都会选择第二个选项！农业时代对人类社会比现在更为脆弱，即使是土地经营者也不可能只考虑最大化期望值而无视生存概率。他们必须要重视生产模式的韧性，而不仅是刚性地追求效率。

在一个依赖复杂流通网络的社会中，土地经营者不得不承认很多风险处在自己无法掌控的地区和角色手中。尽管进行自给自足的庄园农业也依赖天时，但这多少会给予经营者一种自己仍在控制局势的安全感。就好比今天人们也知道乘坐飞机不一定比坐小轿车更危险，但是为什么惧怕飞行的人远多于惧怕行车呢？一个特别重要的原因是在飞机上不管遇到任何事故，乘客是几乎没有任何自己应对的可能的，命运绝大多数要交给上天，极小一部分主要指望飞行员。而且我们确实在历史上看到过青铜时代晚期大崩溃这样的重大历史事件。最开始很有可能是一个区域的农业欠收、自然灾害和社会危机。但是随即可能发生了什么事呢？锡的贸易受阻了，青铜生产萎缩了，军队无法维持，社会秩序更加混乱，商路更加危险，然后贸易进一步萎缩。少数几个关键节点出现失效，就足以使一个高度依赖于长途贸易的复杂国际体系出现级联式的系统性崩溃。当然，我们并不是说在古典帝国晚期的人们知道青铜时代大崩溃的情况，他们几乎不可能知道。但是我们更不能假设古人在智力上不如今人，古人完全有能力理性地考虑风险并做出决策。

因此，我们完全可以认为即使自给自足的生产在效率上也未必能够完全压过古典帝国晚期仍存在的商品经济。也会有部分经营者认真考虑去尝试转入自然经济模式。而一旦自然经济占比上升，对市场的需求又会减弱，流通量的减少抬升了单位运输成本，这会刺激更多地主转向自给生产，然后贸易规模又进一步萎缩。也就是说，存在这样一个由自然经济和商品经济的收益与风险决定的阈值。一旦自然经济的相对优势达到阈值，就会触发正反馈循环，进而使得自然经济无可阻挡地崛起。更重要的是，古典帝国晚期确实会产生一些有利于降低阈值的风险结构变化，其来源相对独立于帝国社会本身的发展。比如说，帝国边境的蛮族在长期与帝国接触的过程中也会经历显著的社会进步，在帝国边境造成越来越大的威胁（个别属于偶发性的迁徙行为更加增强了威胁）。因此古典帝国在晚期不得不面对更多被迫要打的战争，税负上升，（在罗马）官僚体制变得复杂，甚至主动贬值货币。我们还可以考虑一些学者提到的不利于帝国的气候变动。总而言之，古典帝国在其晚期会遇到不少抬高商业流通成本和风险的因素，这进一步削弱了商品经济的竞争力，大大方便了自然经济的发展。

奴隶制社会：奴隶制社会：凡是该社会中存在剥削现象，并且在剥削形式中以人身占有和强迫劳动直接剥削被剥削者劳动力的方式占主导（对经济活动中的比例而言）的社会，都可以称为奴隶制社会。奴隶制社会不一定绝大多数人口都是奴隶，甚至可能大部分人口都不是奴隶。同样的，存在甚至允许奴隶制度的社会，也不一定能够被称为奴隶制社会，比如参与三角贸易的欧洲国家。甚至于被某种程度上直接剥削初级劳动力的人，也不一定能在身份上被划为奴隶，例如一些自由民也会被国家要求强制服役。

这种修正有助于解决奴隶制社会在世界各地评价千差万别的状态，我们指出这个新定义确实有一定合理性。原因在于，在早期国家相对落后的生产力条件下，经济剥削确实是收集并利用社会剩余的主要方式，而社会剩余的去向将直接决定社会的演化方向。因此如果我们忽略那些因为数量不足且过于分散而无法被有效投资的社会劳动生产成果，重点观察可能被执行有效投资的部分，那么奴隶制社会这个定义确实反映了早期国家的本色。

早期国家：这个概念更加模糊，我的观点是，凡是能够达到国家形态，但是又显然处于前古典和前封建状态（之所以强调前封建，是因为我们已经看到一些地区可以不经由古典时期直接封建化）的国家统统都称为早期国家。哪怕这样会把一些看起来已经相当成熟和复杂的国家都归为早期国家（比如新王国时期的埃及）也在所不惜。早期国家存在的剥削方式中奴隶制占了主体，血缘仍然在国家政治组织中占有重要地位。早期国家能够控制的地区十分有限，其统治严重依赖于城市（城邦）作为统治据点，受自然环境限制大。

旧贵族：这个说法具有共产主义国家的特色，我在使用的时候是指早期国家中的统治阶级。他们由氏族首领，宗教祭司和军事领袖演变而来，在当年被视为具有血统上的尊贵性。旧贵族统治的基础在于其对于生产要素的垄断，尤其值得注意的是知识。旧贵族经常同时具有奴隶主的身分。

部族：这个概念也相当模糊而且基本不太可能有什么共识。我在使用的时候指的是一定地域范围内所有部落的集合体，地域认同在一定程度上超越了血缘关系，某种基于文化和语言的共同意识产生了。部族一般来说还处于前国家阶段，但也可能在一些情况下被视为早期国家，这取决于世界公认的标准。

部族联盟：由部族形成的政治实体，包含数目众多的部落。与部落联盟不同的地方在于，我在使用部族联盟时强调了首领继承的稳定性，部族联盟的统治者不再是各个部落推举产生，而是长期处于一个部落并且具有世袭性质。

社群（Community）：与学界的通用标准无异，但是我在使用的时候可能没有那么严格，有的时候会作为“社会群体”的简称出现。

文明（Civilization）：虽然这个概念的定义不太可能让每个人都达成一致，但我在使用的时候与国际通用标准没有区别。

国家（Country）：国家的精确定义是什么？历史上哪些政权算国家？这显然又是一个不可能取得一致的问题，但我在使用的时候与国际通用标准没有区别。

国际通用标准：我在这里对于一些难以达成共识的概念所说的遵循“国际通用标准”是指这样一种原则。假设对于某一个元素，世界上绝大多数学者都认为他应该属于某一个集合，那么我也会认为该元素属于这个集合。如果世界上绝大多数学者都认为这个元素不属于该集合，那么我也会认为该元素不属于该集合。比如说对于公认的国家或者文明我肯定也会把他们视为国家或者文明，但是公认没有达到国家标准的政权或者没有达到文明标准的文化，我也不将其视为国家和文明。

官僚国家：当然不能说存在某种官僚制度的国家都是官僚国家，除了相当原始的早期国家以外，所有国家都拥有或简单或复杂，目的不一的官僚制度。当我说“官僚国家”这个词的时候，指的一定是这个国家的官僚制度对于分配社会资源（包括看得见摸得到的，比如土地和金银，也包括看不见摸不着的，比如权限和信息）和确定社会地位具有决定性的作用。换言之，个人或家族的命运高度依赖于其在官僚体制中的位置，与其他因素都没有什么直接关系。不是因为一个人拥有巨大的财富，崇高的社会地位，妇孺皆知的名望，对社会生产起到重要作用而在官僚体制中获得高位，而是因为官僚体制中的高位所以前面所有东西都可以轻易取得。一般国家的官僚体制受多种社会力量的制约，而官僚国家的社会围绕官僚体制运转。从历史上看，强有力的阶级利益共同体是阻止官僚国家出现的主要力量。在官僚国家内部，不存在一个具有广泛认同的，核心利益一致的，具有强大政治力量的阶级联盟。

治理型官僚制度：最普通的官僚制度。它的主要目的是维持现有社会的正常运行。官僚制度的治理性主要反映的是国家实际干预社会生活，有效实施政治决策的能力，它主要与基础性权力有关。

掠夺型官僚制度：我有的时候也称为榨取型官僚制度，它是一种可能出现在长期战争或军事对抗中的官僚制度。它的主要目标是高效彻底地搜刮所有社会剩余，甚至可能做出杀鸡取卵的事情。在某些情况下这种官僚体制榨取出的巨额财富能够进行有效投资，但是在绝大多数情况下基本上都是“取之尽锱铢，用之如泥沙”。官僚制度的掠夺性主要反映的是国家政权破坏社会惯例，无视各个社会团体意愿的能力，它主要与专制性权力有关。20 世纪布尔什维克统治下采取中央指令性计划经济的国家在一些情况下就可以被视为掠夺型官僚国家，例如 30 年代的苏联。

窒息型官僚制度：或者称作压迫型官僚制度。它的主要目的是不计成本地消灭任何可能造成社会现状发生改变的因素。这种官僚制度为了实现其目的可能需要庞大的特务机构，并且成为警察国家。然而软性手段同样可以达成消灭文化的目的，明清时期的复辟官僚国家基本上就做到了，只不过这需要对人进行长期的驯化。官僚制度的窒息性对于专制性权利和基础性权利都有一定程度的要求。

窒息型的官僚国家一般都会有比较明显的掠夺性，使其与掠夺型官僚国家相区分的特征是后者掠夺社会财富的目的在于进行某种投资（包括军事目的）。但是很多时候因为政治宣传的欺骗性，人们难以完全分清有些政府投资的根本目的是不是就在于“弱民”，例如 20 世纪后半叶中国和阿尔巴尼亚的大规模战备运动。我在做区分的时候基本上都是论结果不论宣传，除非政府用民脂民膏进行的投资真的有可观的回报，我才说这种官僚制度是掠夺型的。

社会剩余：我在使用时指的是一个社会在满足了所有成员的基本生存需求之后，所剩余的资源、财富、时间或能力。

社会生产剩余：虽然可能会有人怀疑我为什么要定义两个非常相似的概念，但是我在使用它们时确实是有分别的。我在使用社会生产剩余这个概念时指的是整个社会的劳动所创造出的除必要的用于维持原有社会存在以外多余出来的资源、财富、时间或能力。“维持原有社会存在”的成本显然不低于“满足所有成员的基本生存需求”，因为行政、宗教、流通和军事

诸多方面都需要投入。所以对于同一个社会来说，除非过于原始，它的社会生产剩余都明显少于社会剩余。

社会效率：指的是社会剩余被用于扩大再生产，进行科教文艺投资，完善公共服务和福利，推进人道主义事业，促进消费的比例。

历史序列：即人类社会演进的顺序。依次是前国家社会，早期国家，古典社会，封建社会，近世社会和现代社会六个历史阶段。不是每一个民族都有必要经历，或者说有运气经历迄今为止全部阶段。同样历史上很多国家并没有办法划归到其中任何一个阶段，不过我们完全可以以这个历史序列为依据对人类古代史上的政权进行定位。像中国这样完全脱离历史序列的国家，我在有的时候称其为“脱轨国家”，以示其完全偏离了人类社会正常发展的轨道。

在这里，我们再补充说明一下历史研究对象的尺度问题。也就是说，当我们研究某个地区的社会在历史序列上如何变动的时候，究竟什么样的研究对象才是“合法的”研究对象？读者读完整个文稿，想必对于什么样的空间单元才有资格被当做一个独立的历史演化对象有了答案：即这个社会是否能够在较长时间内主要依靠自身内部机制完成制度、阶级、文化和经济结构的演化。一般来说，处于开放世界中的社会想要达到独立演化标准，社会规模就必须足够大，否则其社会结构重构和制度演化就会主要受外部体系支配，而不是主要依靠自身内部力量。而地缘上极其孤立的社会规模即使很小，也有可能可以视为一个独立演化的合法研究对象。比方说神圣罗马帝国的某个邦国人口几十万，面积几千平方公里，但是它的贸易体系依附于帝国，宗教体系依附于教会，军事体系依附于更大的政治共同体，技术扩散来自整个西欧，无论如何是不可能形成独立演化的。而古代太平洋上的某个岛国面积同样不大，人口可能更少，但是其社会结构和生产体系完整，极少有对外交流，制度变迁的动力主要来自于内部。那么，即使它再简单，也是具备独立演化能力的。独立演化的能力不是绝对的，其强弱是一种连续谱。像中国、印度、日本、法国、英国的独立演化能力就非常强。但朝鲜、缅甸、北欧这些地区有自己的演化能力，但是明显受到大型文明圈的影响。而神圣罗马帝国和意大利的小邦国则几乎不被视为有自主性，基本可算作从属于更大体系。一个更大研究对象的内部仍有细分的可能，比如北印度和南印度的历史演进并非完全相同。一些地区在一段时间内可以被视为独立单元，但是后来被更大的体系吞并，因此失去了独立演化能力，比如云南。一些地区因为政治上的独立，其独立演化的能力变强了，比如越南。一些地区的自身的独立演化会被外力中断，然后从一个新的位置重新开始，比如拉丁美洲。在近东地区，不少

地区反复易手，其独立演化进程受到了各文明圈的共同影响。随着西方世界在十七、十八世纪的决定性崛起，它对于整个世界产生了极为强烈的影响。哪怕是过去演化独立性很强的地区，比如印度和中国也受到了冲击。总而言之，独立的历史研究对象，是指其社会结构演化主要由内部动力决定，而非由外部体系决定的共同体。

大扩张：指在以铁器使用为代表的重要技术支持下，一些族群改造自然的能力大幅增强，进而通过大范围的征服剧烈扩张了文明的范围，并且在被征服地区迅速发展出具有早期国家水平的社会的长期过程。这一历史现象在公元最后一个千年尤为显著，其结果是在欧亚大陆形成了一批古典帝国。大扩张为原生的古典社会形成创造了必要条件。

还有一点值得注意的是，正是在大扩张时期，因为频繁的战争和劳动力的相对稀缺，奴隶占社会总人口的比例反而比早期国家时期要大，过去人们对于奴隶制社会那种“普遍驱使奴隶进行强迫劳动”的刻板印象或许更多反映的是大扩张时期的面貌。

古典特征：政权疆域空前（甚至是绝后）辽阔，君主权力强大，军队能征善战，官僚机构（相对）成熟，国家能力强，统一的度量衡和法典，社会结构（相对）复杂，具有一个集权的大首都，政府专制性权力和基础性权力同时高涨，使用某种四方通语，城市生活繁荣，商品经济活跃，贵金属大量流通，社会风气开放，女性地位较高，社会意识包容性强，多种学派共存，国家（君主）赞助大型学术机构和学者个人，理性主义流行，重视思辨，科学和技术领域学术成果多，大型工程涌现，公共服务良好等等

典型古典国家（帝国）：典型古典国家有的时候我也写作真正的古典帝国，其建立的基础是土地取代劳动力成为首位生产要素过程中引起的阶级交替，即地主阶级正在取代旧贵族成为新的地主阶级（但此时自然经济尚不占主导）。这个过程中既产生了大量脱产官僚，又使得统治阶级（因为正在更替）难以形成统一的利益诉求，这为古典官僚体制的形成和君主专制的增强提供了条件。典型古典国家的国家能力非常强大，这意味着其基础性权力达到了近世以前的最高水平。典型古典国家包括元首制时期的罗马帝国，西汉帝国，印度笈多王朝，后期萨珊帝国，应当包括高棉帝国（但资料太少），某种意义上还包括院政时期的日本。典型古典国家会具有绝大多数古典特征。古典国家因为其官僚体系的强劲我有时也称其为古典官僚国家。

古典官僚体制：即古典官僚国家一般会形成的官僚体制。古典官僚体制的特点在于官员的出身复杂，意识形态多元化，入仕方式多样。虽然古典官僚体制可能形成一套维持自身运行的规则，但是统治者依据个人需求和喜好任免黜陟官员仍然是古典官僚体制运转的主要动力。比起近代国家和现代国家的官僚体制，古典官僚体制的一个特征是选官制度比较简陋。

原生古典国家：经由公元前的大扩张直接形成的古典国家，而不是在更晚的时期在外界的强烈影响下形成的古典国家，只存在于希腊—罗马，波斯，印度和中国。根据观察，基本只有原生古典国家能在某个阶段表现为典型古典国家。

形成期古典国家：特指中国战国时期的大诸侯王国。由于诸夏所主导的大扩张进程发生得比较早，在大扩张的后半段部族和社群已经被大幅消灭了。因此古代中国的封建主义萌芽和阶级交替现象在战国晚期就已经变得十分明显，这成为各诸侯国变法的先决条件，但此时中国尚未统一。

古典社会：典型古典国家所具有的社会形态就是古典社会。

古典时期：狭义的古典时期即典型古典国家存在的历史时期，广义的古典时期向前追溯到典型古典国家的形成期，向后延伸到典型古典国家的崩溃期。在更加不严格的说法下，一些相对落后地区出现的具有某些古典特征的政权存在的时期，也被视为该地区的古典时期。

古典时代晚期（Late Antiquity）：依照西方历史学家的定义。

古典帝国：狭义的古典帝国就是典型古典帝国。广义的古典帝国标准可以宽松，但是至少应该确保其在历史发展序列上不发生错位。这就是说，一旦认定某个政权是古典帝国，那么这个政权建立前当地社会处在的历史阶段不能比古典时期晚，这个政权结束之后当地社会处在的历史阶段不能比古典时期早。例如科尔多瓦哈里发国在伊比利亚建立之前，其实伊比利亚半岛已经封建化了，那么它就不能视为古典帝国，充其量属于一种晚期古典帝国。同样复辟官僚帝国也不属于古典帝国，因为中国北方在南北朝时期已经出现了明显的封建化特征。桑海帝国在被摩洛哥人击溃之后，其统治的范围内不仅没有明显的封建化现象，反而退回了一群早期国家甚至部落林立的状态，不同民间宗教仍然盛行，那么他也不能视为古典帝国，充其量是因为在贸易网络中具有重要地位而高度发达的早期国家。同样匈奴帝国也不能真的被视为古典帝国，因为蒙古地区在之后没有出现过一个古典帝国，而且直到明代后期封建化才比较明显。我把这种判断原则称为序位不变原则，就是在事实上坚持如下观点：哪怕所谓的

古典特征有千千万万，但是古典时期的本质始终是作为早期国家向封建社会过渡的“过渡时期”。公认的古典国家应当具有一定数量的古典特征，在我谈到古典帝国的时候一般指的是广义的古典帝国，否则我会强调自己说的是真正的古典帝国。

重冈俊阜：这个词语在汉语里的字面意思是高山。我用它来形容人们对于古典时期和古典帝国所拥有的厚重滤镜，古典辉煌的伟大被过分地夸大了，并且被寄予了太多不切实际的希望。

鼎盛时期的古典帝国或古典帝国的鼎盛时期：当我用这种说法的时候指的是非常非常字面意思的古典国家表面上最强大的历史时期。我唯一想提醒读者的一点是，古典帝国的鼎盛时期和古典社会的存在时期具有差别，一般来讲古典帝国表现最为强大的时代阶级过渡已经基本完成了，封建生产方式占据了主流，因此在时间上要晚于古典社会。帝国之所以还没有因为封建化衰退是因为土地兼并的程度还比较低，自然经济的封建庄园还没有广泛出现。

早期古典国家（帝国）：指在社会尚未发展到古典社会阶段就已经表现出许多古典特征的大帝国。包括波斯阿契美尼德王朝，安息帝国，贵霜帝国（存疑），孔雀王朝等。这种政权的存在基础在于中央对于经济流通的控制以及地方部族和社群的自治。

输入型古典国家：特指中国周边的一系列政权。这些政权自身的社会并未发展到古典社会阶段，但是在中国的影响下过早引入了中国的官僚制度尤指唐代复辟时期的官僚制度，因此表现出了一些古典特征。这类国家包括高句丽、百济、新罗和统一新罗，飞鸟奈良时期的日本，渤海国和南诏。

古典游牧帝国：指匈奴，匈奴属于大扩张这一历史事件在东亚游牧地区发生的外溢，因此具有明显的古典性质。

异常古典国家：指朝鲜半岛的王氏高丽政权。这个国家确实处于古典社会阶段，但是错误地引进了中国的复辟官僚制度。

贸易型伪古典国家：指社会远未发展到古典社会阶段，但是因为该地区在国际贸易中处在关键位置，因此在外界影响下呈现出了一定古典特征。包括阿克苏姆、室利佛逝、可萨汗国、马里和桑海等。这类国家非常脆弱，远非真正的古典国家，一旦其贸易地位丧失或者因为军事失利崩溃，当地社会在很长时间内仍会缺乏封建化迹象。

人地型伪古典国家：指社会远未发展到古典社会阶段，但是因为人地关系失衡，地少人多的情况非常明显，因此初级劳动力作为首位生产要素的地位受到土地的挑战。加之精细化生产和复杂协作需求的出现，该国家呈现出了一定古典特征，特别是官僚体制的异常高度发达。具有代表性的例子是乌尔第三王朝。这类国家不管是从体制，环境还是军事方面来说都是脆弱的。

晚期古典国家：指古典社会已经结束之后，封建化已经极其明显的历史时期仍然维持部分古典特征，尤其是保留古典官僚体制的国家。这种类型的国家依赖于自身国际贸易中的地位以及政府对于流通的控制。最典型的晚期古典国家是拜占庭帝国，还至少应该包括科尔多瓦哈里发国，可能包括了孟加拉国的波罗王朝。

蛮族：在古典帝国晚期大举进入文明核心地区各民族的统称，这个名字不代表蛮族相对于古典帝国一定多么落后，只是强调其相对于古典帝国“他者”的身份。蛮族在入关之后引起生产力水平的增长使其具有大量占据土地的需求，因此成为封建化的主力军。

入关：这是一种非常中国化的表述，指的是弱小民族或势力通过军事胜利征服一个大国的过程。

复辟官僚国家：指在古典社会已经完全结束后，封建经济体制已经出现的情况下，因为官僚制度反常的强大导致封建地主阶级没有取得政治上的统治地位，未能进一步向封建领主演化，封建化过程被中断进而倒退，官僚国家重新出现的一种政治状态。复辟官僚国家包括隋唐之后的中国，从中国独立之后的越南，以及朝鲜李朝。

复辟官僚国家与晚期古典国家的本质在于后者在事实上对于封建化缺少应对能力，只能延缓但是无法阻止封建化对于古典官僚体制的冲击，仍然具有解体的倾向。但是复辟官僚国家掌握了完全打压封建地主阶级的政治手段，阻止了大土地所有制的形成，使地主阶级在政治上与被统治阶级同样属于被官僚国家压迫的地位，排除了封建化对于专制君主和官僚政体的威胁，君主的专制性权力在封建经济制度存在的同时极为反常的增强。

复辟官僚制度：复辟官僚国家所实施的官僚制度，从唐至清一直在有所变化并且不断增强。

特别值得注意的是，很多西方研究者都认为复辟官僚制度对于社会剩余的惊人浪费是一种“失策”，但实际上，有计划地销毁社会剩余，使社会生产剩余几乎不产生本身就是复辟官僚制度维持自身存在的手段。因为任何被有效利用的社会生产剩余都有可能带来复辟官僚制

度不想看到的变化，这与其维稳的目标是相悖的。然而，官僚体制自身有过度膨胀的属性，复辟官僚体制在全然不受监督的情况下更是如此。因此，复辟官僚体制无法做到生产多少社会剩余就销毁多少。它总会导致这样一个结果，那就是自身销毁的社会财富越来越多，以至于维持社会基本的公共服务和再生产都不可能。一旦感受到危机，复辟官僚制度可能会试图自救，但是每一次自救尝试都使其自身更为庞大，更为具有破坏性。最终的结果是社会进入总崩溃的状态，这也就是中国历史上所谓“王朝周期律”的衰亡部分。

退潮：这是我本人使用的一种描述。它是指某一历史序列中的社会阶段，当然主要是封建社会，在没有自行地演化到向下一个社会阶段运动时，其政治经济制度就开始瓦解的现象。例如隋唐时期的官僚国家复辟，受西方影响下的伊斯兰世界和印度，都可以称作“封建化退潮”。

伪近（现）代化：指完全没有完整经历过封建社会阶段和近世社会阶段的地区仅在西方世界的影响下引进了主要发达国家中世纪盛期以来创造的科学、技术、以及部分组织、制度和思想，但是其社会存在对于这些过于先进的舶来品产生了强烈抵制的现象。伪近（现）代化在全世界极为普遍。

宗教教义：宗教教义是指一个宗教的核心信仰，基本原则和世界观。简单来说就是宗教告诉人们应该信什么。

宗教教法：宗教教法是根据宗教教义所制定的、规范信徒行为的法律和规章，是对教义的具体化和应用。教法的作用是指导信徒在日常生活中的行为规范，包括宗教仪式，伦理道德，社会关系等方面。简单来说就是宗教告诉人们应该怎么做。

古典宗教：回应了古典社会的各种诉求，对于各种类型的“古典国家”都有较好适应能力的宗教。以大乘佛教为典型，可能包括了拜火教，早期基督教的一些分支和高棉化的印度教，某种意义上也包含了汉代经学（不过我还是认为儒学不属于宗教）。古典宗教在晚期古典社会可能发生适应性变化，神秘主义倾向和非公开仪式会增加，并且对于君主进行进一步的神化，最为典型的例子是金刚乘佛教，同时应当包含东正教。

封建宗教（封建化宗教）：能够适应封建化这一历史进程的要求，对于封建化早期阶段维系社会的基本流通和技术投资起到重大作用的宗教。相比于古典宗教，封建宗教最大的特点在于深入社会基层，面向人民群众，修行方式简化，强调“因信得救”，教会和教团发达并且

积极参与社会活动。典型的封建宗教有天主教、日本佛教和上座部佛教，还应该包括埃塞俄比亚正教，印度教和伊斯兰教的大部分派别，某种意义上还有藏传佛教。但是我想强调的是宗教并非某个社会的本质特征，宗教对于社会存在的变化具有很强的适应性，具体判断的时候不应该望文生义。

封建宗教的结束：随着一个地区从封建社会进入近世社会，世俗的国家机关和各类社会组织都在迅速扩大其能力。近世社会在客观上已经不再需要封建宗教在社会生活中扮演中世纪年代那样重要的作用。宗教因为其固有特征，在协助经济流通和技术投资上的效率已经被近代新生的各种机构所超越。宗教对于社会意识形态的影响也并不利于科学观念在全社会普及。因此在国家向近世转型的时期，各种形式反对封建宗教的运动就必然出现，从最温和的宗教改革到织田信长镇压一揆那样最暴力的活动人们都可以在历史上见到。经过近代化洗礼的宗教在组织上（包括教义和教法两方面）便不会有中世纪那样管理严格，对一般社会生活的参与程度大大下降。当然，就像欧洲宗教改革所表明的，新的教派在道德戒律的要求上可能更严格。在宗教改革时期工商业经济最发达地区出现的新教派，例如基督教新教，在这种意义上可以被称为一种近世宗教。

封建圣战：指在封建宗教的鼓动下，以获得土地并在被征服地区实行封建制度为目的，最终使得征服者转变为统治阶级的战争。最典型的封建圣战是中世纪盛期开始德意志人在波罗的海地区发动的一系列十字军战争。伊斯兰政权所发动的许多吉哈德（Jihad）也具有封建圣战的性质，但是因为伊斯兰世界的封建化一直不完全，因此从结果看不是那么典型。不是所有拥有宗教圣战口号的敌对行动都属于封建圣战。

古典通语：有的时候是古典通文。指古典帝国官方认定并且在帝国各地广泛使用的一种语言或文字，在古典帝国结束后的封建时期仍然会作为封建宗教教会使用的语言，直到慢慢被封建民族语言取代。

封建民族语言：封建时期所形成的各民族的语言，准确地说，封建民族语言就是日后区别各个民族的主要特征之一。封建民族语言的出现使得古典通语基本退出历史舞台。包括英语、德语、阿姆哈拉语、孟加拉语、泰语等等。

地主-官僚妥协：指蛮族在北中国与汉族地主阶级所达成的一种妥协。少数民族入侵者放弃剥夺汉族地主的土地所有权以实现本民族的封建化，转而使各级酋长转变为各级官僚使本民

族官僚化。少数民族中的底层百姓迅速沦落为官僚体制下悲惨的平民，与汉族百姓没有区别，而少数民族统治者则成了专制君主。汉族地主保有了自己的土地并且像过去一样仍然作为官僚参与到国家政治中。这一过程使得北中国的土地所有权乃至土地产权在民族大迁徙的冲击下十分稳定，官僚体制完全没有被封建化摧毁，为官僚复辟国家的形成奠定了基础，是中国封建化失败的主要原因。在伊斯兰征服的过程中可能也出现了类似的现象。

官位荣禄收买：指中国复辟官僚国家刚刚建立的隋唐时期，政府对于作为大土地所有者的门阀士族所采取的暗中削弱措施。统治者授予门阀士族官僚体制中的高位，诱使他们维护官僚体制的权威，向长安和洛阳集中居住，防止其成为土地领主。复辟官僚国家有效地削弱了门阀士族得以形成的基础，即对于生产资料和生产控制，以及基于土地承担军事义务的能力。这种表面上的重视再加上明里暗里的打压使得门阀士族在三个世纪内走向了衰亡，自此中国的地主阶级无法在政治上发出值得关注的声音。

官僚化地主：读者看到这里应该对于这种中华帝国晚期被称为“乡绅”的群体的性质很熟悉了。我把这些概念列出来是想强调，“官僚与地主的对立”与“官僚与地主的密不可分”，在复辟官僚国家是同时存在的现象。对立指的是官僚阻止的地主夺权：地主的正常演进方向是发展为进行政治统治的封建领主，而官僚体制阻止的这一点并将地主纳入自身。这就是演变路径上的对立，而不是结果上的泾渭分明。官僚化地主的社会地位和权利主要来自官僚体系，而非对生产资料的掌控。他们作为次要的经济身份是地主，而主要的政治身份是官僚。

在地领主：在自己所拥有的土地上居住，参与庄园生产管理的封建领主。在地领主具有较强的改良经营方法，提高农业水平的热情和能力。

汉制：指经过第七个皇帝汉武帝刘彻统治时期的更化运动所形成的中国特有的古典官僚体制支持的政治制度。汉制形成于汉匈战争的高潮时期，带有非常浓厚的战时色彩，表现出了极强的动员力和掠夺性。汉制在军事和技术领域的投资非常成功，它在两个世纪内被证明是一种可怕的战争手段和政府干预推动技术进步及推广的典范。与一般的古典官僚体制不同，汉制下的古典官僚体制赋予了整个官僚系统统一的意识形态和能自行新陈代谢的选官制度及评定、黜陟标准。这导致了一个存在共同价值观念的，通过官僚体制受益的，与官僚体制高度绑定的士大夫阶层的出现。汉制的这些特点在日后成为中国封建化失败，复辟官僚国家重建的重要原因。古典中国结束之前的魏晋政治制度也可以被视为汉制在封建化初期的一种演变。

唐制：即唐代所实施的政治制度，是复辟官僚国家出现之后的里程碑。唐制虽然为当时仍然强大的门阀士族在政治中留有地位，保有大量的封建化特征。但是其最终目的始终是完全消灭封建化对于官僚国家产生的威胁，并且的确有实现目的的能力。唐制因为短期内能够维持很强的军事能力，且意外地能够使用在古典时代和古典时代前的一段时间，对于中国周边造成了极大的破坏。

宋制：即宋代所实施的政治制度，是复辟官僚国家完全成熟的标志。宋制完全消除了封建地主阶级对于复辟官僚体制的威胁，不再为贵族阶层在中国的政治结构中留有任何位置，将整个社会无差别地置于复辟官僚国家的统治之下。但是宋制仍然有在危急时刻释放封建因素以保全自身的灵活性存在。宋制属于中国社会进程演变出的高度特化的政治体制，几乎很难被其他国家学习因此危害较小。

中华帝国晚期：在汉语语境中指的就是明清两代。

本位面：指我们生活的这个世界。

乱纪元：指难以预测的大规模灾难性事件频发的历史时期。

政治效率：指的是一个政治体系（例如国家、政府、政党等）在实现其既定目标或满足社会需求方面的能力和效率。它衡量的是政治体系以最少的资源投入，取得最大成果的能力。

社会存在（social being/social existence）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用时指的是人们在一定历史时期所处的社会物质生活条件的总和，特别是他们的生产方式、生产关系以及这些关系所决定的社会结构。

社会意识（social consciousness）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用时指的是在一定社会存在基础上产生的反应社会存在的各种思想观念，观点，情感，心理以及表达这些内容的各种形式的总和。有的时候我也把它叫作社会观念。

社会基础：我在使用时指的是构成一个社会正常运作和稳定存在所必要的各种要素和条件的总和。

民智：理性层面的知识以及获取、理解和掌握知识的能力，加上感性层面的情感以及产生，感知和表达情感的能力。

民力：主要指的是以体力劳动为代表的初级劳动力，但是在实际使用的时候不止于此，例如中国统治者驱使百姓投入战争也属于榨取“民力”的一部分，战争显然不属于生产性的劳动。

生产力（productive forces）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候是指特定社会在生产过程中改造自然，获取物质资料的能力。

生产关系（Relations of Production）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候是指人们在生产过程中形成的相互关系，是人们在物质资料的生产，分配，交换和消费过程中所处的地位和相互联系的形式。

经济基础（economic base）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候指的是一定社会中占统治地位的生产关系的总和，是构成社会形态的基础。

上层建筑（superstructure）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候指的是建立在一定经济基础上的，为维护该经济基础服务的各种政治、法律、意识形态和文化设施的总和。

劳动生产率（Labor Productivity）：是一个衡量经济效率的重要指标，它反映了单位劳动投入所产生的产出数量。简单来说，就是衡量工人在单位时间内创造了多少价值或生产了多少产品。

基础性权力（Infrastructural Power）：依照迈克尔·曼（Michael Mann）的观点，它是指国家通过社会基础设施（如法律、行政机构、教育系统、交通网络、通信系统等）渗透和协调社会各个领域的的能力。基础性权力强调制度化、合作性和长期影响。在中华帝国，行使基础性权力的主要是第九章第七节提到的一般行政官僚。因为行使基础性权力让官僚容易通过占有生产资料转化为统治阶级，所以对于最高统治者来说，一般行政官僚最好是流官。

专制性权力（Despotic Power）：依照迈克尔·曼（Michael Mann）的观点，它是指国家统治者在不受制度约束的情况下，随意干预社会生活的能力。专制性权力强调随意性、压制性和短期影响。在中华帝国，行使专制性权力的主要是第九章第七节提到的高度特化的扩大并维护君主利益的官僚。它们高度依附于最高统治者，不容易向统治阶级转化，对于最高统治者来说，这些奴才最好具有世袭性。

中世纪和中世：我在使用欧洲人所说的“中世纪”，日本人所说的“中世”以及“封建社会”这三个概念的时候不做任何区分，他们指的就是一回事。以欧洲的标准来说，大约指的

是公元 500 年到公元 1500 年这一千年间的社会形态所界定的时段。有的时候这个概念还被表述为“中古”。

中世纪早期或封建早期：即公元 500 年到公元 1000 年间西欧社会的形态所界定的时段。

中世纪盛期或封建盛期：即公元 1000 年到公元 1300 年间欧洲西部社会的形态所界定的时段。中世纪盛期是社会全面复兴的历史时期，在这个阶段，人口和经济规模等主要社会指标超过古典时期的水平。

中世纪晚期或封建晚期：即公元 1300 年到 1500 年间欧洲西部社会的形态所界定的时段。

近世：也就是“近代”。封建社会瓦解之后到现代社会形成前的历史时期。

近世社会：由封建社会向资本主义社会（现代社会）过渡的一种社会形态，其特征包括民族国家形成，专制主义统治，频繁发动对外战争且军费开支居高不下，经济流通激增，思想解放和科学革命，等级制度瓦解，市民阶层兴起等等。因为西方学者对于他们自己的近代历史早就研究了千百遍，我也不可能有什么补充的。我唯一想强调的就是近世社会具有和古典时期相似的阶级过渡特征，资本取代土地成为首位的生产要素，资产阶级正在代替封建地主阶级成为国家的统治阶级。社会各个阶层力量的相对平衡以及诉求的不一致，成为近世国家绝对君主制能够建立并维持一段时间的社会基础。尽管必然会引起争议，但我坚持把江户时期的日本也划为近世国家。全世界只有极少数国家经历过近代社会，经历过近代社会几乎能够视为成为如今发达国家的先决条件（排除掉袖珍国家。同时承了宗主国宗教、文化、语言特征的原殖民地国家在独立前的历史进程视为与宗主国相同，因为这些原殖民地国家基本复制了宗主国的社会结构）。

绝对君主制：专指在近世社会统治阶级发生过渡的条件下，君主既不受封建制度的制约，又不受资产阶级国家机关的制约形成的君主专制性权力高涨的政治体制。我在使用这个词的时候将其非常严格地限定在近世的君主制国家，以波旁王朝的法国作为代表。任何社会没有到达近世阶段但是君主拥有很大专制性权力的政治体制都不能被视为绝对君主制，不管是奥斯曼帝国，明清帝国，印加帝国还是像现在的文莱、沙特阿拉伯都不行。

绝对主义（Absolutism）国家：与学界通用的定义没有区别。

近世国家：以近世社会为基础建立的国家。君主制的近世国家一般都会在某一时期发展出绝对君主制的特征。有个别近世国家看起来很早就变成了共和国或者是虚君政治（即君主立宪

制），但是人们应当注意这些国家本土面积都很小，实际上不存在相对独立的发展进程。它们原本应当是一个更大的近世政权中政治平衡的一部分，也即工商业经济最为发达的地区，但是因为欧洲复杂的政治变动最终独立，荷兰就是这样的。

资本主义：我本人从来没出过国不曾见过，而且这种经济制度出现的社会阶段离中国实在过于遥远，因此无法作出任何评价。就按照学界公认的标准即可。

资本主义社会：同上，我本人难以了解，应当为实行资本主义经济制度并资产阶级占有统治地位的社会。我想说的是资本主义社会在绝大多数运转比较好的地区都建立在当地经历过近世社会的基础上，要么就曾是在地理大发现以后开辟的殖民地。显然绝不是随便一个发展阶段的社会强行移植资本主义经济制度就能够变成资本主义社会。现在我只能看到大韩民国这样极为罕见的例外，考虑到中国和朝鲜半岛历史进程之间的联系，我认为韩国的成功对于中国来说具有非常大的价值。

资本主义国家：同上，我本人难以了解，基于资本主义社会建立的国家，据我所知资本主义国家的民主程度是有史以来最佳的，这或许正是反映了封建盛期以来社会重组的意义。但是现代社会和资本主义社会究竟能不能等同，似乎并没有定论。

现代社会和现代国家：难以评价，我很难具体知道这两个概念是什么样子。目前看起来资本主义社会就是现代社会的代名词，现代国家就是资本主义国家。

现代性（Modernity）：我基本认同现代性是一种与传统社会相对立的社会发展和文化形态，其核心在于对理性、科学、进步和普遍性的信仰。它起源于欧洲的启蒙运动，并在 19 世纪和 20 世纪逐渐扩展到全球，但是除了发达国家以外，其他地方的社会对现代性的接纳是非常有限的。

后现代性（Postmodernity）：据称，后现代性是对现代性的反思和批判，认为现代性所追求的理性、科学、进步和普遍性都是虚假的，它强调多元、差异、相对性和解构。但是因为我国社会距离现代尚且遥遥无期，因此我并不能够准确理解什么是发达国家认为的后现代性。

欧洲各个部分的界定：据我所知，如何划分西欧、北欧、东欧、南欧和中欧原本就没有统一的标准，对于我一个没有出过国的中国人来说就更加困难。我在讲封建化早期的“西欧”时，一般指的就是西罗马帝国的欧洲，核心是英格兰，法国、北意大利、低地地区和德国西部的一些地区。但是为什么在有的时候又会采用“欧洲西部”这个称呼，原因是历史本来就是动

态变化的。一个最简单的例子就是德意志这个概念在中世纪盛期大幅度向东扩张了，如果说公元十世纪的时候说“德国是一个西欧国家”还很合理，但是 1300 年的神圣罗马帝国怎么都更像一个中欧国家。因此我在讲西欧或者欧洲西部的时候其实就是想指封建欧洲的核心地区，这个概念确实在随时间扩大，而东欧、北欧则处于对应方位词所限定的外围地区。

东亚：今天中国、朝鲜、韩国、越南、日本五个国家领土所涵盖的范围。新疆和西藏因为属于中国，所以我也认为它们在东亚地区。但是我在指新疆时会认为它属于“亚洲内陆”，在指西藏时只会说它属于青藏高原的主体。

汉地：即汉族占优势多数的土地。基本上就是清代包括直隶在内的 18 个行省所界定的范围，不包括现在汉族占绝大多数的中国东北地区。在更早的时间段进行描述的时候，像云南贵州这样的地区可能并不被算在汉地里，不过读者一想就能明白，也不影响理解。

中原：中国的文化地理概念，以河南省为中心，向关中、江汉、淮泗、河朔等周边辐射的广大区域，被视为中华民族的摇篮和文明中心。

东北亚：日本、朝鲜、韩国、中国东北地区和俄罗斯远东地区所涵盖的范围，应该跟公认的东北亚是完全一致的。

朝鲜：我在说到朝鲜或者朝鲜人的时候基本指的都是整个半岛或者整个半岛的居民。如果说的是北朝鲜政权，那么结合语义应该非常容易判断。

欧亚大草原：跟学界的定义没有区别。

东南亚：与一般的划分没有区别。不过我有的时候在说东南亚的时候可能是指排除掉华莱士线以东部分以及整个菲律宾的东南亚。

南亚：我在说南亚的时候指的是印度，巴基斯坦，孟加拉国，尼泊尔，不丹，斯里兰卡和马尔代夫这七个国家领土所涵盖的范围，并不包括阿富汗。

中亚：我在说中亚的时候指的是哈萨克斯坦，吉尔吉斯斯坦，塔吉克斯坦，土库曼斯坦，乌兹别克斯坦和阿富汗六个国家，我把阿富汗算作中亚，但是不把新疆算作中亚。

中东：我在说中东的时候指的是被地中海、黑海，大高加索山脉、里海和印度洋所限定，在土耳其、塞浦路斯、埃及和伊朗包围之内的地区，当然也包括这四个国家的领土。

近东：我在说近东这个概念的时候基本上就是指伊斯兰征服前的中东，但是具体包含的地区要小，不包括阿拉伯半岛中南部不邻红海的地区以及除了西南部的伊朗高原（因为伊朗西南部有埃兰文明所以划入近东）。